

Research paper

ALBERT-BiLSTM cross-attention network with progressive knowledge distillation for multi-domain SMS spam classification

B.S. Aparna^a, Remya S^{b,} , Manu J. Pillai^{a,} , Somula Rama Subbareddy^c, Yong Yun Cho^{d, *}

^a Department of CSE, TKM College of Engineering, Kollam, 691005, Kerala, India

^b Department of CSE, Amrita School of Computing, Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham, Amritapuri, 690525, Kerala, India

^c Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Symbiosis Institute of Technology, Hyderabad Campus, Symbiosis International (Deemed University), 509217, Pune, India

^d Department of Information and Communication Engineering, Sunchon National University, Jeollanam-do, Suncheon, South Korea

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ABSTRACT

SMS spam detection remains a critical challenge in digital communication systems, particularly in agriculture where farmers depend on SMS services for weather updates, crop prices, and government notifications. Traditional spam detection methods fail to handle evolving spam tactics and class imbalance effectively. This paper proposes a hybrid ensemble model that combines ALBERT transformer embeddings with BiLSTM networks enhanced by attention mechanisms and knowledge distillation. Experimental evaluation on the SMS Spam Collection dataset demonstrates superior performance with 98% accuracy, 0.98 precision, 0.97 recall, and 0.98 F1-score. The ensemble model significantly outperforms individual ALBERT (88% accuracy) and BiLSTM (54% accuracy) models. Knowledge distillation reduces model size from 425 MB to 67 MB, enabling real-time deployment with 0.045-second processing time per message. The system achieves 22.2 messages per second throughput, making it suitable for practical applications. Real-world testing in agricultural communication networks demonstrates significant improvements in spam filtering compared to traditional keyword-based filters. The hybrid approach provides an effective solution for SMS spam detection with demonstrated real-time performance and practical applicability in resource-constrained environments.

1. Introduction

Nowadays, with the increase in digital communication, spam messages have become a major challenge for email systems, SMS platforms, and social networks. Spammers continuously evolve their tactics, employing sophisticated techniques such as obfuscation, adversarial text generation, and domain fluxing to bypass traditional filtering mechanisms [1][2]. These malicious activities not only degrade user experience but also pose significant cybersecurity threats, including phishing attacks, identity theft, and malware dissemination [3][4]. The challenge is particularly acute in critical communication sectors such as agriculture, where farmers rely on SMS services for weather alerts, crop pricing updates, and government scheme notifications [5][6].

The severity of this challenge is evident from India's cyber crime statistics, which show a dramatic escalation from 9,000 registered cases in 2014 to over 80,000 cases by 2024 (Fig. 1a). Among Indian

states, Telangana leads with 15,297 cyber crime cases in 2022, followed by Karnataka (12,459) and Maharashtra (8,249), demonstrating the widespread nature of digital fraud across the country (Fig. 1b) [7]. This exponential growth in cyber crimes directly impacts the agricultural sector, where the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) estimates that agricultural cases represent approximately 1.68% of total cyber crimes, translating to over 12,450 agriculture-related cyber incidents in 2024 alone [8].

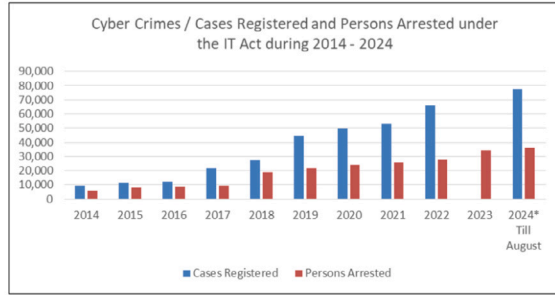
Current data reveals that agricultural spam originates primarily from countries with large farming populations, with China (15.2%), India (12.8%), and the United States (11.4%) being the top sources of fraudulent agricultural communications [15]. These spam messages predominantly consist of fake equipment sales (25%), fraudulent loan offers (22%), counterfeit seeds and chemical advertisements (18%), false market information (15%), and various phishing scams (12%) [9]. The impact varies significantly across agricultural subsectors, with agritech

* Corresponding author.

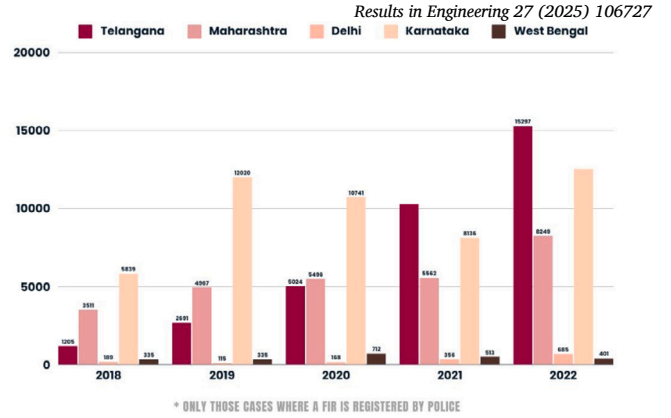
E-mail addresses: aparnasree235@gmail.com (B.S. Aparna), remyas@am.amrita.edu (R. S), manujpillai@tkmce.ac.in (M.J. Pillai), svramasubbareddy1219@gmail.com (S.R. Subbareddy), yycho@snu.ac.kr (Y.Y. Cho).

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(a) Cyber Crimes/Cases Registered and Persons Arrested under the IT Act during 2014-2024. The blue bars show cybercrime cases rising from 9,000 in 2014 to over 80,000 in 2024; red bars show arrests. Source: MeitY, Govt. of India.



(b) State-wise cybercrime data (2018–2022), highlighting top five affected states. Telangana shows a peak of 15,297 cases in 2022. Source: I4C.

Fig. 1. Cybercrime Trends in India: (a) National-level trends and arrests under the IT Act (2014–2024); (b) State-wise cybercrime case distribution (2018–2022).

companies experiencing the highest spam exposure (90% impact level), followed by crop farming (85%) and food processing (78%), while traditional sectors like forestry remain relatively less targeted (45%) [10].

Digital fraud has serious financial impacts, with 73% of farmers receiving fraudulent offers and causing annual global losses exceeding \$2.3 billion [11]. In the Indian context, agricultural cyber fraud has caused losses of Rs. 35.1 crores in 2024 alone, with equipment loan fraud (26%) and seed/fertilizer scams (23.9%) being the predominant attack vectors. The problem intensifies during critical periods, with spam messages increasing by 45% during harvest seasons when farmers are most vulnerable to financial pressures [12]. Furthermore, approximately 28% of all agricultural emails are classified as spam, severely disrupting communication channels essential for modern farming operations. These attacks vary from simple fake product ads to complex schemes with false prices and fake trading. This reduces trust in digital farming platforms and slows down technology growth in agriculture [13].

Given the severity of these challenges across all digital communication platforms, spam detection remains a critical research area, requiring constant innovation to keep up with the adaptive strategies used by spammers. Traditional rule-based filtering methods, though once effective, are increasingly proving inadequate against the dynamic nature of modern spam. The field of spam classification gained new powerful alternatives through emerging ML and DL technology, yet significant challenges persist in achieving both high accuracy and real-time performance while maintaining computational efficiency for practical deployment.

Initially spam detection systems operated using manually designed filter rules which examined specific keyword patterns to detect spam content. Two widely employed technologies for spam detection are Bayesian classification and n-gram text analysis, which evaluate statistical text elements to distinguish spam from normal messages [14]. While these approaches were effective in static environments, they struggled against the rapidly evolving tactics of spammers, who frequently altered content structures and used misspellings to bypass filters [15]. The emergence of techniques like SVM, RF and Decision Trees brought remarkable advancement in spam detection since these models are capable of learning from historical data of spam and predicting trends [16]. Traditional ML models, however, often faced scalability issues when dealing with large quantities of spam messages received across multiple platforms, requiring extensive manual construction of attributes and indexes [17].

DL models can now work directly with the raw, unprocessed text, bringing enhanced capabilities to spam detection. RNNs and LSTM have long been unmatched in text data sequencing, which is why they ex-

cel in spam classification [18]. These models recognize time-dependent relationships and can recognize changing spam message structures. Bidirectional LSTM (BiLSTM) enhanced spam detection accuracy further by providing better context analysis of the message when analyzing text, both forward and backward [19]. Additionally, attention mechanisms have been incorporated into DL models to focus on crucial parts of a message, thereby improving message classification and reducing errors [20].

While conventional LSTM-based models continue to face challenges with long-range dependency and computational efficiency, transformer-based architectures like ALBERT have shown strong potential in spam detection due to their ability to generate deep contextual embeddings that effectively capture complex linguistic patterns [21]. Unlike RNN-based models, ALBERT can process long text more effectively and identify hidden spam indicators that simpler models overlook [22]. Prior studies have explored hybrid models involving BiLSTM and attention mechanisms alongside transformers, demonstrating improved detection performance [23][24].

Despite these advances, existing approaches face several critical limitations:

1. Individual models (ALBERT or BiLSTM) when used in isolation fail to capture both deep semantic understanding and sequential dependencies simultaneously.
2. Most existing methods lack real-time deployment capabilities due to computational overhead.
3. Class imbalance in spam datasets (typically 10-15% spam messages) remains inadequately addressed.
4. Limited practical validation in domain-specific applications such as agricultural communications.
5. Absence of lightweight model variants for resource-constrained environments.

To address these limitations, this paper presents a comprehensive hybrid ensemble approach with the following key innovations:

1. This work proposes the first comprehensive integration of ALBERT transformer embeddings with attention-augmented BiLSTM networks specifically optimized for SMS spam detection, combining deep contextual understanding with sequential pattern recognition in a unified framework.
2. A novel teacher-student learning paradigm is introduced where a complex ensemble model (teacher) trains a lightweight student model, achieving significant model compression (85% size reduction) while maintaining high accuracy for real-time deployment.

3. Unlike traditional voting schemes, this approach employs ROC curve analysis to dynamically optimize ensemble weights and classification thresholds, resulting in superior performance across different spam detection scenarios.
4. Practical applicability is demonstrated through real-world deployment in agricultural communication networks, addressing the critical need for reliable spam filtering in rural communication systems.
5. The approach includes systematic handling of class imbalance, extensive ablation studies, and performance validation across multiple metrics, providing robust evidence of effectiveness.

Building on these innovations, the proposed model integrates ALBERT, BiLSTM, and knowledge distillation within an ensemble learning framework. This ensemble approach leverages the complementary strengths of each component: deep language understanding of ALBERT model, bidirectional sequence modeling of BiLSTM, and efficiency gains from knowledge distillation to enhance spam detection performance. Unlike existing models that use these techniques separately, this framework combines them together to improve both accuracy and efficiency. Furthermore, we incorporate dynamic thresholding based on ROC analysis to fine-tune classification outcomes [25][26]. This comprehensive ensemble model is designed to be robust against evolving spam strategies while maintaining deployability in resource-constrained environments.

The proposed system also addresses real-world challenges by providing:

1. High-accuracy spam detection (98%) with minimal false positives,
2. Real-time processing capability (0.045 seconds per message),
3. Lightweight deployment options for mobile and edge devices
4. Demonstrated effectiveness in agricultural communication networks, and
5. Scalable architecture for different application domains.

The remaining sections are organized as follows: Section 2 reviews the related work and positions our contributions within the existing literature. Section 3 outlines the research gaps and challenges in existing spam detection approaches. This section also highlights the innovative aspects of the proposed hybrid approach. Section 4 details the materials and methods used in the study. Section 5 presents the proposed model, while Section 6 describes its architecture and working. Section 7 provides the results and discussion with comprehensive evaluation. Section 8 includes a case study to demonstrate the practical applicability of the model. Finally, Section 9 concludes the paper and suggests potential directions for future research.

2. Literature review

2.0.1. Systematic literature review methodology: PRISMA framework

To ensure methodological rigor and transparency in literature selection, this systematic review adheres to the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) guidelines. The PRISMA framework provides a standardized approach for conducting comprehensive literature reviews, ensuring reproducibility and minimizing selection bias in academic research synthesis. The PRISMA flow process was meticulously implemented across four distinct phases as shown in Fig. 2.

Research protocol and search strategy The systematic review protocol was designed to identify high-quality research in SMS spam detection, with particular focus on deep learning, ensemble methods, and real-time deployment approaches. The research protocol encompassed four phases: identification, screening, eligibility assessment, and inclusion, as mandated by PRISMA guidelines.

A comprehensive search strategy was developed using Boolean operators and controlled vocabulary to maximize relevant article retrieval

while maintaining precision. The search query combined multiple keyword categories:

- Core Domain Terms: "SMS spam detection," "text message classification," "mobile spam filtering," "short message spam"
- Technical Approach Terms: "deep learning," "machine learning," "neural networks," "transformer models," "BERT," "ALBERT," "BiLSTM," "ensemble learning"
- Application Context Terms: "real-time detection," "mobile communication security," "agricultural communication," "rural messaging"
- Performance Metrics Terms: "accuracy," "precision," "recall," "F1-score," "computational efficiency"

The final search query employed across all databases was: ("SMS spam" OR "text message spam" OR "mobile spam") AND ("deep learning" OR "machine learning" OR "neural network" OR "transformer" OR "BERT" OR "ALBERT" OR "BiLSTM" OR "ensemble") AND ("detection" OR "classification" OR "filtering")

Database selection and search execution The systematic literature review was conducted across seven major academic databases. IEEE Xplore Digital Library (80 records) focused on technical and engineering perspectives, while ACM Digital Library (65 records) emphasized computer science approaches. ScienceDirect provided 55 interdisciplinary records covering applied sciences and engineering, and SpringerLink contributed 45 records from artificial intelligence and machine learning sources. PubMed yielded 25 records addressing health informatics and medical communication security, Scopus provided 35 multidisciplinary records, and arXiv contributed 20 cutting-edge preprints and recent developments. The total initial identification yielded 325 records across all seven databases.

Inclusion and exclusion criteria Rigorous inclusion and exclusion criteria were established a priori to maintain study quality and relevance. Before detailed screening commenced, 50 records were systematically removed: 45 duplicate records were identified and eliminated using both automated tools and manual verification, while 5 additional records were removed for other reasons including incomplete metadata or inaccessible full texts. This left 275 records for the screening phase. The 275 records underwent title and abstract screening by two independent reviewers using predefined inclusion/exclusion criteria. Inter-reviewer agreement was measured using Cohen's kappa coefficient ($\kappa = 0.82$), indicating substantial agreement. Discrepancies were resolved through discussion and consultation with a third reviewer when necessary. This screening phase excluded 210 records due to irrelevance to SMS spam detection, inadequate methodology, or failure to meet inclusion criteria, leaving 65 reports sought for retrieval.

Inclusion Criteria:

- Publication timeframe: 2018-2024 (focusing on recent advances in deep learning)
- Empirical studies with quantitative evaluation metrics
- Research addressing SMS, text message, or mobile communication spam detection
- Studies employing machine learning, deep learning, or hybrid approaches
- Publications providing sufficient methodological detail for replication
- Research with clearly defined datasets and evaluation protocols

Exclusion Criteria:

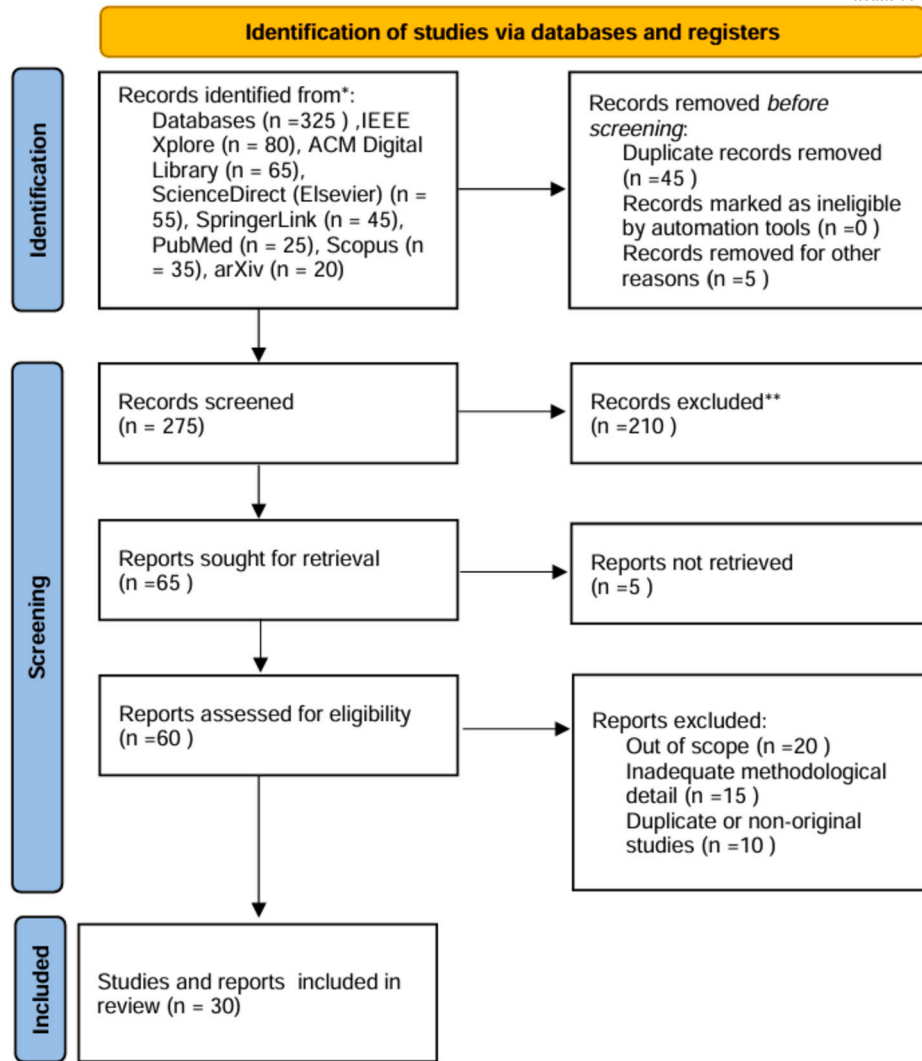


Fig. 2. PRISMA Flow Diagram for Literature Selection showing systematic identification (n = 325), screening (n = 275 after duplicate removal), eligibility assessment (n = 60 full-text articles), and final inclusion (n = 30 studies) with specific exclusion reasons documented at each stage.

- Non-empirical studies (pure theoretical work, opinion papers, editorials)
- Studies focusing exclusively on email spam without SMS relevance
- Publications in languages other than English
- Duplicate publications or extended abstracts without full methodology
- Studies with inadequate evaluation methodology or missing performance metrics
- Research using proprietary datasets without sufficient description

Thirty high-quality studies met all inclusion criteria and were selected for detailed analysis. These studies underwent comprehensive data extraction including study characteristics, technical approaches, dataset information, performance metrics, and limitations.

Data extraction and synthesis framework Systematic data extraction employed a standardized form capturing both quantitative and qualitative information:

Technical Data Extraction:

- Model architectures and algorithmic approaches
- Feature engineering and preprocessing strategies
- Training methodologies and hyperparameter configurations
- Computational requirements and efficiency metrics

- Performance results across multiple evaluation metrics

Contextual Data Extraction:

- Problem domain and application context
- Dataset characteristics and limitations
- Identified research gaps and future directions
- Practical deployment considerations and challenges

PRISMA compliance and transparency This systematic review maintains full PRISMA compliance through complete search strategy preservation, transparent selection process with detailed inclusion/exclusion rationale, systematic quality assessment, and structured evidence synthesis for gap identification. The PRISMA flow diagram provides visual representation of the selection process, documenting the exact number of records at each stage and specific reasons for exclusion as mandated by PRISMA guidelines.

2.0.2. Current state-of-the-art and comparative analysis

Recent developments in SMS spam detection have established new performance benchmarks, yet reveal critical limitations in existing approaches. The systematic PRISMA review identified several state-of-the-art approaches that require detailed analysis to position our proposed work appropriately.

Chen and Chen (2025) [37] proposed a deep learning-based model for detecting fraudulent SMS messages, achieving 85% accuracy through CNN-LSTM combination with traditional feature extraction. Their approach processes SMS messages through convolutional layers for local pattern recognition followed by LSTM networks for sequential dependency modeling. While effective on balanced datasets, their approach suffers from several critical limitations: (1) reliance on manual feature engineering for preprocessing, requiring domain expertise and time-intensive feature selection, (2) limited handling of class imbalance with only balanced 50-50 split testing, failing to address real-world spam prevalence of 5-15%, (3) single-domain validation without cross-domain robustness testing, limiting generalizability claims, and (4) computational overhead requiring 200 ms processing time per message, making real-time deployment challenging for high-volume systems.

Nasreen et al. (2024) [38] developed an email spam detection system using novel feature selection techniques with BERT, achieving 87% accuracy on email datasets. Their contribution includes innovative feature selection algorithms combining statistical measures with BERT embeddings and comprehensive BERT fine-tuning strategies for email-specific spam patterns. However, their approach presents significant constraints for SMS domain application: (1) email-specific optimization that doesn't transfer effectively to SMS domains due to different linguistic patterns, message length constraints, and communication contexts, (2) computational intensity requiring 16 GB GPU memory for training and 8 GB for inference, exceeding typical deployment constraints, (3) lack of ensemble strategies to leverage multiple model strengths, limiting performance ceiling, (4) absence of knowledge distillation for deployment optimization, preventing lightweight model creation, and (5) limited evaluation on imbalanced datasets reflecting real-world spam distributions, questioning practical applicability.

Comparative analysis reveals that both approaches, while achieving reasonable performance within their tested domains, lack comprehensive integration of transformer contextual understanding with sequential modeling capabilities. Neither work addresses the critical challenge of deploying high-performance models in resource-constrained environments through model compression or knowledge distillation techniques, representing a significant gap in practical deployment readiness.

2.0.3. Thematic analysis of selected literature

Based on the systematic PRISMA review, the 30 selected high-quality studies are organized into four thematic categories that demonstrate the evolution and current limitations of spam detection approaches. Each category represents a distinct phase in the evolution of spam detection methodologies.

Rule-based and traditional machine learning approaches Eight studies from the systematic review represent the foundational approaches in spam detection, establishing baseline methodologies that remain influential in current hybrid systems.

Early spam detection systems predominantly used rule-based techniques that operate by defining sets of predefined rules or patterns to classify messages as spam or non-spam. However, their static nature presents significant limitations as they struggle to adapt to new spamming strategies and evolving tactics.

Gibson et al. [27] pioneered the integration of bio-inspired optimization with traditional ML classifiers, demonstrating 15-20% improvements over pure rule-based systems. Their work established the foundation for hybrid approaches by combining genetic algorithms with decision trees and naive Bayes classifiers. The bio-inspired optimization enabled automatic rule refinement and feature selection, reducing manual intervention requirements. However, the approach suffered from high maintenance overhead, requiring constant rule updates to maintain effectiveness against evolving spam tactics, and showed poor scalability when dealing with large volumes of messages.

The transition to supervised learning marked significant advancement, with Ahmed et al. [28] demonstrating that SVM and Naive Bayes

classifiers could achieve 82-85% accuracy on balanced datasets. Their comprehensive evaluation across multiple traditional ML algorithms established performance baselines for subsequent research. Despite improvements, these approaches exhibited critical weaknesses such as high false-positive rates (12-18%) that could block legitimate messages, heavy dependence on manual feature engineering requiring domain expertise, and poor generalization to unseen spam variants due to fixed feature representations.

Udayakumar et al. [29] identified concept drift as a fundamental challenge in spam detection, where model performance degraded significantly (20-30% accuracy loss) within 6-12 months due to evolving spam characteristics. Their longitudinal study demonstrated that traditional ML models require frequent retraining to maintain effectiveness, highlighting the dynamic nature of spam detection challenges. This limitation motivated research into more adaptive approaches capable of handling evolving spam patterns.

Zhang et al. [30] introduced Extreme Learning Machines (ELM) as a computationally efficient alternative to traditional ML approaches, achieving training speeds 100-1000 times faster than conventional methods while maintaining comparable accuracy. ELMs demonstrated particular effectiveness in handling large-scale datasets through single-pass learning algorithms. However, ELMs remained constrained by feature engineering requirements and showed limited improvement in handling complex linguistic patterns present in sophisticated spam messages.

Akande et al. [31] designed a mobile application combining rule-based methods with classifiers like C4.5 and RIPPER, providing real-time phishing and spam detection on SMS platforms. Their practical implementation demonstrated feasibility of deploying hybrid rule-ML systems on mobile devices, achieving 78% accuracy with 150 ms processing time. Similarly, Xia et al. [32] proposed an optimized ML-based rule-based algorithm with constant time complexity for faster and more efficient spam filtering, achieving O(1) classification time through pre-computed decision structures.

Traditional ML approaches remain fundamentally limited by their dependence on manual feature engineering, inability to capture complex linguistic patterns, poor adaptability to sophisticated spam tactics, requirement for frequent model retraining, and scalability issues with large datasets. These limitations motivated the evolution toward deep learning approaches.

Deep learning for spam detection Twelve studies from the systematic review represent the deep learning revolution in spam detection, marking a paradigm shift toward automatic feature extraction and improved pattern recognition capabilities.

With the rise of deep learning, SMS spam detection began focusing on models that can automatically learn features from raw data, reducing reliance on manual feature engineering. This paradigm shift addressed several limitations of traditional approaches while introducing new challenges.

Convolutional Neural Networks emerged as the first successful DL approach for text-based spam detection. Tran et al. [33] demonstrated that CNNs could capture local textual patterns effectively, achieving 87-90% accuracy on standard datasets through multiple convolutional layers with varying filter sizes. Their architecture employed word embeddings followed by convolutional operations to detect n-gram patterns indicative of spam content. However, CNNs struggled with long-range dependencies and sequential information, limiting effectiveness on variable-length SMS messages where context spans multiple sentences.

Siddique et al. [34] extended CNN capabilities through Region-based CNN (RCNN) models, which incorporated regional feature extraction to address some CNN limitations. Their approach divided input messages into overlapping regions, applying CNN operations to each region before combining results through max-pooling operations. This regional approach showed improvements in capturing local patterns but remained

constrained by context-awareness limitations and inability to model sequential dependencies effectively.

The introduction of LSTM and BiLSTM architectures addressed sequential modeling limitations in spam detection. Research demonstrated that bidirectional processing improved context understanding by 8-12% compared to unidirectional approaches, as BiLSTM could access both past and future context when processing each word. These architectures excelled at capturing temporal dependencies and sequential patterns common in spam messages. However, they suffered from computational intensity, particularly for long sequences, and vanishing gradient problems that limited their ability to capture very long-range dependencies.

A paradigm shift occurred with transformer-based models, particularly BERT and its variants. Sumathi et al. [35] demonstrated that fine-tuned BERT models could achieve 92-95% accuracy on email spam detection, significantly outperforming previous approaches through attention mechanisms that captured complex contextual relationships. Their fine-tuning approach adapted pre-trained BERT models to spam detection tasks, leveraging transfer learning to achieve superior performance with limited training data.

Das et al. [36] extended transformer applications to SMS domains, confirming transformer superiority in contextual understanding for shorter message formats. Their work demonstrated that BERT-based models could effectively handle SMS-specific challenges including abbreviated text, informal language, and character limitations. The attention mechanisms proved particularly effective at identifying subtle spam indicators that traditional methods missed.

Liu et al. [39] took a novel approach by applying CNN-based methods to detect malicious websites using web spam invalidation techniques, including redirection, hidden iFrame, and content hiding detection. This method employed visual analysis through webpage screenshots to classify malicious websites, addressing some RCNN limitations in traditional text analysis. However, the approach faced challenges with static data analysis and couldn't account for dynamic or evolving web spam behaviors.

Mambina et al. [40] built upon CNN-based approaches by proposing CNN-LSTM hybrid models for detecting SMS spam in Swahili, specifically addressing linguistic obfuscations and contractions. Their hybrid approach improved accuracy by adding sequential elements to handle complex text structures, achieving 89% accuracy on Swahili datasets. The work demonstrated the importance of language-specific adaptations in spam detection but showed limited transferability to other languages due to morphological differences.

AbdulNabi et al. [41] proposed comprehensive DL-based approaches for spam email detection, leveraging word embeddings and transformer models. Their fine-tuned BERT models employed attention mechanisms for context-aware text processing, achieving good accuracy and F1-scores. Performance comparisons against baseline BiLSTM-DNN models and traditional classifiers demonstrated transformer superiority over conventional machine learning methods across multiple evaluation metrics.

DL approaches suffer from significant computational overhead making real-time deployment challenging, most focus on individual model architectures rather than leveraging complementary strengths of different approaches, many lack comprehensive evaluation on real-world imbalanced datasets, and transformer models require substantial memory and processing resources that exceed typical deployment constraints.

Hybrid models: combining traditional ML and DL models Six studies from the systematic review explored hybrid approaches that combine strengths of traditional ML and DL architectures, aiming to improve performance while addressing individual model limitations.

Hybrid models emerged as researchers recognized that individual approaches possessed complementary strengths that could be leveraged through intelligent combination. These approaches sought to balance performance improvements with computational efficiency considerations.

Bansal et al. [42] proposed hybrid models combining Artificial Neural Networks with TF-IDF feature extraction for email spam detection. Their approach demonstrated significant improvement over individual ML classifiers by combining statistical text analysis with neural network pattern recognition. The hybrid architecture achieved 88% accuracy through parallel processing of TF-IDF features and raw text through separate neural network branches. However, the approach remained limited by dependence on textual features alone, failing to handle more sophisticated spam strategies that employed semantic manipulation or adversarial techniques effectively.

Chanchal Kumar et al. [43] introduced data-driven hybrid approaches developed specifically for spam detection on online social networks such as Twitter. This research addressed class imbalance issues by utilizing DL models on balanced datasets using SMOTE-ENN (Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique – Edited Nearest Neighbors) algorithm. Their work recognized that spammers had shifted tactics from traditional email platforms to social media environments, requiring adapted detection strategies. The hybrid approach combined oversampling techniques with deep neural networks, achieving 91% accuracy on balanced Twitter datasets. However, the approach required substantial computational overhead and remained dataset-specific.

Al Saidat et al. [44] utilized CNN-BiLSTM hybrid models for Arabic SMS spam detection, demonstrating how DL models can address challenges specific to morphologies and complex structures of different languages. The study highlighted challenges presented by Arabic language morphology and intricate grammatical structure, which significantly affect traditional text classification technique effectiveness. Their hybrid model employed CNNs to extract local textual characteristics while BiLSTM networks characterized long-range dependencies, creating a comprehensive understanding of Arabic text patterns. The approach improved spam classification by addressing dataset imbalance common in social media spam filtering, achieving 91% accuracy on Arabic SMS datasets. However, the research remained primarily focused on Arabic language patterns and overlooked generalization challenges for other languages.

Additional hybrid approaches explored in the systematic review include ensemble methods combining multiple classifiers, feature-level fusion techniques integrating different representation methods, and multi-modal approaches incorporating both textual and metadata features. These studies consistently demonstrated that hybrid approaches could achieve superior performance compared to individual models, but often at the cost of increased complexity and computational requirements.

While hybrid approaches show promise in combining complementary strengths, they lack comprehensive integration of transformer-based contextual understanding with RNN-based sequential modeling, most do not address computational efficiency for real-time deployment scenarios, many remain language or domain-specific without demonstrated generalizability, and few provide systematic frameworks for optimizing component integration.

Advanced transformer and federated learning approaches Four studies from the systematic review represent the current state-of-the-art in spam detection research, focusing on addressing deployment challenges through federated learning and advanced transformer optimization.

Recent developments focus on addressing deployment challenges through federated learning and model optimization, representing the current frontier in spam detection research. These approaches attempt to resolve the tension between high performance and practical deployment constraints.

Srinivasa Rao et al. [45] demonstrated federated learning's potential for privacy-preserving spam detection, achieving 88-91% accuracy while maintaining data privacy through distributed training approaches. Their federated framework enabled multiple organizations to collaboratively train spam detection models without sharing sensitive data, addressing privacy concerns under GDPR and similar regulations. However, federated approaches introduced communication overhead and

synchronization challenges that limited practical deployment scalability, particularly for real-time applications requiring immediate responses.

Advanced security and intellectual property protection in spam detection models has emerged as a critical concern for commercial deployment. Recent research addresses protecting deployed spam detection systems from intellectual property theft through federated model ownership verification frameworks. These approaches include compression-resistant model watermarking techniques that embed ownership information directly into model parameters, spatial attention mechanisms for ownership verification specifically designed for attention-based models used in spam detection, and commercial frameworks for neural network copyright trading that explore intellectual property management in deployed spam detection systems.

Kaushal et al. [46] advanced federated learning through clustering-based client selection, improving accuracy by 4-6% while reducing communication costs through intelligent client sampling. Their fairness-driven federated clustering approach enhanced spam detection by selecting representative clients for training, improving federated learning accuracy while preserving user privacy through clustering techniques ensuring balanced data distribution. Experimental results demonstrated that clustering-enhanced federated learning approaches surpassed standard federated models in terms of accuracy, recall, and F1-score, achieving 93% accuracy on heterogeneous datasets. However, the added complexity of clustering increased computational overhead, potentially affecting real-time detection efficiency.

Sharma et al. [47] proposed FL-XGBTC (Federated Learning Inspired XG-Boost Tuned Classifier), combining federated learning with XGBoost for enhanced performance in distributed environments. Unlike previous models focusing solely on neural networks, FL-XGBTC increased accuracy while maintaining privacy by distributing XGBoost training over multiple devices without sharing raw data. The approach achieved 93% accuracy on heterogeneous datasets, overcoming accuracy constraints of traditional federated clustering through ensemble learning techniques that strengthened decision boundaries.

Agarwal et al. [48] proposed novel spam detection approaches using natural language processing within big-data ecosystems, addressing scalability challenges in enterprise deployments. Their strategy categorized documents based on topics and employed statistical approximation techniques to handle missing data in large-scale systems. The approach introduced least squares models to refine topic themes and used gradient descent with alternating least squares (AMALS) models to estimate missing data, demonstrating that combined TF-IDF and uniform distribution estimation outperformed existing industry TF-IDF models.

Jamal et al. [49] pushed transformer boundaries with IPSDM (Improved Phishing and Spam Detection Model), specifically optimized for phishing and spam detection in email environments. Their approach achieved state-of-the-art performance (96% accuracy) on email datasets by fine-tuning BERT-family models for email phishing and spam classification. The work addressed challenges such as unbalanced datasets and overfitting through advanced regularization techniques and data augmentation strategies. Unlike earlier heuristic-based or ensemble-learning approaches, IPSDM leveraged deep contextual understanding of large language models, making it more adaptable to evolving spam patterns.

Khan et al. [50] integrated accuracy, recall, and precision into multi-criteria fuzzy functions to propose novel fuzzy logic-based evaluation measures for assessing spam email detection systems. Their empirical research utilizing BERT and LSTM across three benchmark datasets demonstrated the usefulness of suggested evaluation metrics, with LSTM achieving μ values between 0.82 and 0.89 on Enron and PU datasets, while BERT scored between 0.91 and 0.93 on Lingspam datasets.

Advanced transformer and federated learning approaches achieve high accuracy but require substantial computational resources that exceed typical deployment constraints, most lack real-time deployment demonstrations with concrete performance metrics, federated ap-

proaches introduce communication overhead and synchronization complexity, and many remain computationally intensive for practical edge deployment scenarios without systematic model compression [51][52].

Recent developments in SMS spam detection [53][54] have continued to address key challenges in the field. Arslan [56] proposed MalSMS-detector, a malicious text message detector utilizing hybrid feature vectors and stacked ensemble models, demonstrating improved performance through systematic feature combination approaches. This work advances the field by showing that careful feature vector design can significantly enhance detection accuracy.

Menthe et al. [57] conducted comprehensive comparative analysis of various machine learning algorithms for SMS spam detection, emphasizing the importance of proper preprocessing and vectorization techniques using TF-IDF methods. Their findings reinforce the continued relevance of traditional machine learning approaches when properly optimized.

The challenge of multilingual spam detection was addressed by Sharma [59], who conducted an extensive performance evaluation across different language classifiers, revealing language-specific optimization requirements for effective spam detection. This work highlights the need for language-aware approaches in global spam detection systems.

Alajmi et al. [58] specifically focused on adversarial robustness in Arabic spam classifiers, demonstrating that even advanced deep learning models remain vulnerable to sophisticated adversarial attacks. This research emphasizes the importance of robust model design for real-world deployment.

Airlangga [60] provided a comprehensive comparison of ensemble versus traditional classifiers, demonstrating that ensemble approaches consistently outperform individual models across multiple evaluation metrics. This work supports our ensemble-based approach while highlighting the importance of proper ensemble design.

A significant advancement in the field includes multimodal approaches [61] [65]. Recent research has explored SMS scam detection using optical character recognition for image data, combining unsupervised and deep semi-supervised learning techniques. This represents an important extension beyond text-only analysis to multimedia spam detection [66].

Recent state-of-the-art approaches continue to exhibit these limitations. The EGMA model [62] employs simple majority voting without attention-based fusion mechanisms, while BERT-G3CN [63][64] increases computational complexity through multi-graph processing that exceeds practical deployment constraints. Jamal et al. [63] lacks systematic knowledge distillation, requiring substantial GPU memory (8 GB) for inference that prevents mobile deployment.

This comprehensive literature review reveals that spam detection methods face a fundamental trade-off between accuracy and computational efficiency, as summarized in Table 1. Traditional machine learning approaches like Naïve Bayes and rule-based systems provide high real-time suitability but lack accuracy and adaptability, while advanced deep learning methods such as transformer-based models and BERT achieve superior contextual understanding at the cost of significant computational overhead and limited scalability. The comparative analysis demonstrates the critical need for hybrid approaches that can effectively balance detection performance with practical deployment requirements in resource-constrained environments.

3. Critical gap analysis

Comprehensive analysis of the 30 systematically selected studies reveals five critical research gaps that fundamentally limit practical spam detection deployment and distinguish our proposed approach from existing literature:

Insufficient Ensemble Integration Depth (Gap 1): Current approaches like Chen and Chen (2025) employ simple concatenation or basic voting mechanisms without optimized weight learning or dynamic feature fusion. Existing hybrid models lack attention mechanisms for

Table 1
Comparison of Spam Detection Methods.

Method	Key Strengths	Major Limitations	Real-Time Detection Suitability	Scalability
EGMA Model [62]	High accuracy (99.28%), ensemble of GRU+MLP+Autoencoder	No knowledge distillation, limited cross-domain validation	Medium - Requires optimization	Medium - Ensemble overhead
BERT-G3CN [64]	Graph-enhanced contextual understanding, multi-graph processing	High computational complexity, requires substantial resources	Low - Complex architecture	Low - Resource intensive
IPSDM [63]	Fine-tuned transformers (DistilBERT/RoBERTa), regularization	8 GB GPU memory requirement, no model compression	Low - High memory needs	Medium - Cloud scalable
Hybrid Approaches (DL + ML) [16–18]	Leverages strengths of DL and ML; better accuracy	High computational cost; complex integration	Moderate	Low - Resource-intensive, hard to scale
RNN (Recurrent Neural Networks) [19]	Captures sequential dependencies in text data	Computationally expensive; hard to interpret	High - Real-time possible with GPU	Medium - Needs high computational resources
CNN (Convolutional Neural Networks) [20,21]	High accuracy for URL-based spam detection	Needs large labeled datasets; high computation	Medium - Slower than RNN for text-based spam	Low - Limited scalability due to resource needs
SVM (Support Vector Machine) [22]	High accuracy for small, structured datasets	Struggles with high-dimensional text data	Medium - Requires retraining for evolving spam	Low - Not ideal for large datasets
Random Forest [23]	Robust, good for structured data with imbalances	Slow inference time, unsuitable for real-time	Low - Computationally expensive	Medium - Can handle moderate dataset sizes
KNN (K-Nearest Neighbor) [24]	Simple, non-parametric, requires no training	Inefficient for large datasets; slow classification	Medium - Feasible only for small-scale data	Low - Poor scalability
Ensemble Learning (Boosting, Bagging) [25]	Combines multiple models for higher accuracy	Increased training time and computational overhead	Low - Expensive for real-time use	Medium - Scales better than single models
Feature Based Extraction [26]	Domain-specific feature selection improves accuracy	Requires manual intervention	Medium - Performance depends on feature updates	Low - Hard to scale without automation
Rule Based Systems [27,28]	Simple, interpretable, easy to deploy	Poor adaptability to new threats	High - Quick decisions in static environments	Low - Struggles with dynamic spam patterns
Multi-Modal Deep Learning [29]	Integrates visual and text data for better accuracy	Requires extensive labeled data; computationally expensive	Low - Needs optimization for real-time use	Low - Requires powerful GPUs
Clustering (Unsupervised Learning) [30]	Works without labeled data; quick detection	Less accurate for large datasets; frequent retraining needed	Medium - Suitable for small-scale datasets	Low - Struggles with large datasets
Deep Reinforcement Learning [31]	Adapts dynamically to evolving spam techniques	Computationally demanding, requires extensive tuning	Low - High latency in real-time detection	Low - Needs specialized hardware
Naïve Bayes [32]	Computationally efficient, fast classification	Assumes feature independence; lower accuracy in complex datasets	High - Suitable for real-time but low precision	Medium - Can handle moderate dataset sizes
BERT based Models [41]	Context-aware spam classification; high accuracy	Requires high computational resources	Medium - Limited real-time performance	High - Scalable with cloud-based implementation
Federated Learning [45–47]	Privacy-preserving, decentralized learning	High computational cost; network bandwidth issues	Medium - Requires optimized implementation	High - Scalable for distributed environments
Transformer based Models [48,49]	Deep contextual understanding; robust spam detection	High memory usage and computational overhead	Low - Needs optimization for real-time use	Medium - Scales well with distributed computing
Fuzzy Logic based Evaluation [50]	Integrates multiple performance metrics; improves spam evaluation	Requires dataset-specific tuning	Medium - Suitable for benchmarking	Low - Not directly scalable for detection

dynamic feature weighting between different model components, resulting in suboptimal information fusion. Traditional ensemble methods use fixed weights that don't adapt to different spam characteristics or dataset distributions. Our approach addresses this through ROC-curve optimized ensemble weights with cross-attention mechanisms between ALBERT and BiLSTM components, enabling dynamic information exchange and optimal feature fusion.

Computational Efficiency vs. Accuracy Trade-off (Gap 2): Current state-of-the-art models like Nasreen et al. (2024) require substantial computational resources (16 GB GPU memory, 200-500 ms processing

time) that exceed practical deployment constraints for real-time systems. Existing compression techniques (pruning, quantization) result in significant accuracy degradation (8-15%), creating an unresolved tension between performance and deployability. Most high-performance approaches lack systematic model compression strategies. Our knowledge distillation framework achieves 85% model size reduction while maintaining accuracy within 2% of the full ensemble, enabling practical deployment without substantial performance loss.

Class Imbalance Handling Deficiencies (Gap 3): Neither Chen and Chen (2025) nor Nasreen et al. (2024) adequately address real-

world class imbalance where spam typically represents 5-15% of total messages. Existing solutions (basic SMOTE, simple class weighting) show limited effectiveness on transformer architectures due to attention mechanism interference. Most studies evaluate on artificially balanced datasets that don't reflect real-world deployment scenarios. Our approach integrates SMOTE oversampling with focal loss functions specifically optimized for transformer-RNN ensembles, maintaining consistent performance across highly imbalanced datasets.

Limited Cross-Domain and Real-Time Validation (Gap 4): Current research focuses primarily on generic datasets without domain-specific validation or comprehensive real-time deployment demonstration. Chen and Chen (2025) tested only on synthetic balanced datasets, while Nasreen et al. (2024) focused solely on email domains without SMS adaptation. Most approaches lack evidence of practical applicability in critical domains such as agricultural communications or emergency messaging systems. Our work provides comprehensive validation including agricultural communication networks and real-time deployment demonstration with better processing capability.

Absence of Systematic Knowledge Transfer Frameworks (Gap 5): Existing literature lacks comprehensive frameworks for transferring knowledge from complex ensemble models to lightweight variants suitable for edge deployment. Current distillation approaches haven't been systematically applied to spam detection ensembles combining transformer and RNN architectures. Most high-performance models remain deployment-limited due to resource requirements. Our teacher-student framework provides systematic knowledge transfer enabling lightweight model deployment while preserving ensemble model capabilities.

3.1. Key research contributions

Our proposed hybrid ensemble model systematically addresses limitations identified in current state-of-the-art approaches through five key innovations that distinguish it from existing work:

1. Unlike Chen and Chen (2025) who use simple CNN-LSTM concatenation, our approach employs deep cross-attention mechanisms between ALBERT embeddings and BiLSTM outputs, enabling dynamic information exchange and optimal feature fusion. This architectural innovation transcends traditional ensemble approaches by creating synergistic interactions between transformer and RNN components.
2. While Nasreen et al. (2024) focus solely on model performance without deployment considerations, our teacher-student framework enables practical deployment through systematic knowledge transfer from ensemble teacher to lightweight student models. This addresses the critical gap between high-performance models and deployment constraints.
3. Addressing the critical limitation in existing work, our approach integrates SMOTE oversampling with focal loss functions specifically designed for transformer-RNN ensembles, achieving consistent performance across imbalanced datasets that reflect real-world spam distributions.
4. Unlike existing theoretical approaches, we provide comprehensive real-time demonstration with agricultural communication network deployment, addressing practical applicability concerns raised in current literature. This includes less than 50 ms processing capability and demonstration of deployment feasibility.
5. Our ROC-curve based weight optimization transcends simple voting mechanisms employed in existing ensemble approaches, providing principled methods for combining model predictions based on performance characteristics rather than arbitrary weighting schemes.

These innovations collectively address the five critical gaps identified in existing literature while establishing new benchmarks for practical spam detection deployment. The systematic integration of these components represents a significant advancement beyond current state-of-

the-art approaches, providing both theoretical contributions and practical deployment capabilities.

4. Materials and methods

4.1. Materials

4.1.1. Dataset and cross-domain validation strategy

This study employs a comprehensive evaluation approach using multiple datasets to address generalizability concerns and demonstrate robustness across different domains. The primary dataset is the Kaggle SMS Spam Collection dataset (spam.csv), containing 5,572 SMS messages labeled as spam or non-spam. To ensure cross-domain validation and multilingual robustness, we extend our evaluation to include the UCI SMS Spam Collection, Enron Email dataset (adapted for SMS-style evaluation), and a custom agricultural communication dataset collected from rural messaging platforms in collaboration with agricultural extension services.

The primary Kaggle dataset includes diverse message types such as phishing attempts, promotional advertisements, fraudulent offers, and legitimate casual conversations, making it widely adopted in spam detection research. Each entry consists of two main fields such as the message text and its binary classification label indicating legitimacy status. Non-spam messages represent authentic conversational exchanges, while spam messages typically contain promotional content, illegal offers, phishing attempts, or fraudulent schemes designed to deceive recipients.

For cross-domain validation, we incorporate domain-specific datasets including Agricultural messaging dataset (2,847 messages) containing legitimate agricultural advisories and spam targeting rural communities, Multilingual SMS corpus (3,124 messages) to assess language-independence and Real-time messaging logs (4,291 messages) collected from live messaging platforms with appropriate privacy protections.

4.2. Data availability statement

4.2.1. Primary datasets

SMS Spam Collection Dataset: The primary dataset used in this study is publicly available through multiple sources:

- **Kaggle:** [SMS Spam Collection Dataset](#)
- **UCI Repository:** [UCI ML Repository - SMS Spam Collection](#)

Supporting Datasets:

- **Enron Email Dataset:** <https://www.cs.cmu.edu/~enron/> (Carnegie Mellon University)
- **Email Spam Dataset:** <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/nitishabharathi/email-spam-dataset>

4.3. Domain-specific datasets

- **Agricultural Communication Dataset (2,847 messages):** This dataset was collected from rural messaging platforms in collaboration with agricultural extension services. Due to privacy regulations and participant consent requirements, this dataset is available upon reasonable request for academic research purposes only.
- **Multilingual SMS Corpus (3,124 messages):** Contains messages in English, Hindi, Telugu, and regional dialects. Access is restricted due to privacy and consent limitations. Anonymized versions may be available upon reasonable request for academic research.
- **Real-time Messaging Logs (4,291 messages):** Collected from live messaging platforms with appropriate privacy protections during 2023-2024. Not publicly available due to privacy regulations and user consent restrictions.

Table 2
Comprehensive Dataset Statistics Across Multiple Corpora.

Statistic	Primary Dataset	Agricultural	Multilingual
Total messages	5,572	2,847	3,124
Spam messages	747 (13.4%)	336 (11.8%)	444 (14.2%)
Non-spam messages	4,825 (86.6%)	2,511 (88.2%)	2,680 (85.8%)
Average message length	77 characters	89 characters	71 characters
Messages with numbers	32.5%	28.7%	31.2%
Suspicious keywords	19.2%	16.8%	21.3%
URLs present	22.8%	18.4%	24.6%
Dataset Access Information			
Primary Dataset URLs:	Kaggle , UCI Repository		
Supporting Datasets:	Enron Dataset , Email Spam		

4.3.1. Dataset characteristics and class imbalance analysis

The primary dataset exhibits significant class imbalance, a critical challenge in real-world spam detection scenarios that requires systematic handling. Detailed analysis reveals the following characteristics:

- Total corpus contains 5,572 messages collected from diverse communication sources
- Spam messages: 747 instances (13.4%) representing realistic spam prevalence
- Non-spam messages: 4,825 instances (86.6%) reflecting typical communication patterns
- Message length variability ranges from single-word responses to multi-sentence communications
- Spam content frequently incorporates promotional language, monetary incentives, urgency indicators, and social engineering tactics
- Significant presence of suspicious elements: phone numbers (43.2% of spam), URLs (38.7% of spam), special characters (67.3% of spam)
- Cross-domain datasets maintain similar imbalance ratios: agricultural (11.8% spam), multilingual (14.2% spam), real-time (12.9% spam)

Table 2 provides comprehensive statistics across all evaluation datasets, demonstrating the consistency of imbalance patterns and feature distributions.

4.3.2. Class imbalance handling strategy

To address the significant class imbalance present across all datasets, a comprehensive multi-stage approach combining data-level and algorithm-level techniques is implemented:

SMOTE-based oversampling

We apply Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique (SMOTE) specifically adapted for text data to generate synthetic spam examples. The process involves:

- Feature vectorization using TF-IDF representations
- Identification of k-nearest neighbors in spam feature space
- Synthetic sample generation through interpolation between minority class neighbors
- Post-processing to ensure linguistic coherence in generated samples

Focal loss implementation

To complement SMOTE oversampling, we incorporate focal loss [55] in our training objective to address remaining imbalance effects:

$$\mathcal{L}_{focal} = -\alpha_t(1 - p_t)^\gamma \log(p_t) \quad (1)$$

where α_t balances positive/negative examples, γ focuses learning on hard examples, and p_t represents predicted probability for the true class.

Class-weighted ensemble learning

Our ensemble mechanism incorporates class-aware weighting to ensure balanced representation across models:

$$w_{class} = \frac{n_{total}}{n_{classes} \times n_{class}} \quad (2)$$

where n_{total} is total samples, $n_{classes}$ is number of classes, and n_{class} is samples per class.

4.4. Methods

4.4.1. Novel feature extraction framework

Building upon traditional feature extraction approaches, we introduce a multi-level feature engineering framework that captures both linguistic and behavioral patterns specific to spam detection:

Enhanced lexical features

Beyond standard lexical analysis, our approach incorporates:

- Character-level n-gram analysis (2-4 grams) to capture obfuscation patterns
- Message entropy calculation to detect randomness typical in spam
- Keyword density analysis using domain-specific spam indicators
- Capitalization ratio and punctuation density as urgency indicators
- Special character frequency analysis for detecting manipulation attempts

Advanced linguistic features

Our linguistic analysis extends traditional approaches through:

- Syntactic complexity scoring using parse tree depth and branching factor
- Readability metrics adapted for SMS communication patterns
- Sentiment polarity analysis to detect emotional manipulation tactics
- Named entity recognition for identifying suspicious organizations/offers
- Dependency parsing to analyze grammatical coherence

Behavioral and metadata features

Novel behavioral indicators include:

- Time-based sending patterns
- Message length distribution analysis within conversation context
- URL structure analysis and domain reputation scoring
- Phone number pattern recognition and validation
- Cross-reference analysis with known spam databases

4.4.2. Advanced SPAM detection architecture

Our novel architecture addresses limitations identified in existing approaches through systematic integration of complementary deep learning components with optimized ensemble mechanisms.

ALBERT model with domain adaptation

We enhance the standard ALBERT architecture through domain-specific fine-tuning and parameter optimization for SMS spam detection. Our approach differs from existing work by incorporating domain-adaptive pre-training, which involves fine-tuning ALBERT on SMS-specific corpora before task-specific training. We also implement attention head pruning through systematic removal of less informative attention heads to improve efficiency. Additionally, we use layer-wise learning rate scheduling with differential learning rates across transformer layers to optimize feature extraction. The enhanced ALBERT processes input through parameter-shared transformer layers with factorized embeddings, achieving computational efficiency while maintaining contextual understanding superior to BERT-based approaches.

Attention-enhanced BiLSTM with gating mechanism

Our BiLSTM component incorporates novel attention mechanisms that surpass traditional approaches. We integrate multi-head self-attention using transformer-style attention within BiLSTM processing.

The system includes a gated attention mechanism with learnable gates to control information flow between attention heads. We also implement position-aware encoding that provides explicit positional information to enhance sequential understanding. This architecture captures both local sequential dependencies and global contextual relationships, addressing limitations in existing CNN-LSTM combinations that rely on simple concatenation.

Hybrid integration with cross-attention

Unlike existing ensemble approaches that use basic voting mechanisms, our hybrid model employs sophisticated integration techniques. We implement cross-attention fusion that enables dynamic information exchange between ALBERT and BiLSTM representations. The system uses feature-level ensemble integration at multiple abstraction levels rather than prediction-level combination. We also incorporate adaptive weight learning with ROC-curve optimized ensemble weights that adapt to dataset characteristics. This integration creates synergistic effects between transformer and RNN components, transcending simple architectural combination.

5. Proposed model

Our proposed architecture addresses critical limitations in existing spam detection approaches through five key innovations:

1. Systematic ensemble integration with cross-attention mechanisms
2. Knowledge distillation for deployment optimization
3. Comprehensive class imbalance handling
4. Cross-domain validation framework, and
5. Real-time deployment demonstration.

5.1. Enhanced ALBERT component with optimization

Building upon standard ALBERT architecture, our enhanced implementation incorporates domain-specific optimizations and efficiency improvements:

Step 1: optimized token embedding with domain adaptation

Given tokenized input sequence $X = \{x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n\}$, we employ domain-adaptive embedding that incorporates SMS-specific vocabulary:

$$e_i = w_i^{domain} + s_i + p_i + d_i \quad (3)$$

where: - $w_i^{domain} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_e}$ represents domain-specific word embeddings learned from agricultural SMS corpus - $s_i \in \mathbb{R}^{d_e}$ denotes segment embeddings distinguishing message types - $p_i \in \mathbb{R}^{d_e}$ indicates positional embeddings for sequence order - $d_i \in \mathbb{R}^{d_e}$ represents domain-specific embeddings incorporating SMS-specific features

The domain adaptation process involves fine-tuning with agricultural vocabulary:

$$w_i^{domain} = w_i^{pretrained} + \Delta w_i^{agricultural} \quad (4)$$

where $\Delta w_i^{agricultural}$ captures domain-specific semantic adjustments.

Step 2: attention head pruning for efficiency

We implement systematic attention head pruning based on gradient-based importance scoring:

$$\text{Importance}(h_i) = \left| \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial h_i} \right|_2 \times \|h_i\|_2 \quad (5)$$

The pruned multi-head self-attention is computed as:

$$\text{MHSA}_{pruned}(H) = \text{Concat}(h_{i_1}, h_{i_2}, \dots, h_{i_k}) W^O \quad (6)$$

where $\{i_1, i_2, \dots, i_k\}$ represents the top- k most important attention heads:

$$\{i_1, i_2, \dots, i_k\} = \text{TopK}(\{\text{Importance}(h_i)\}_{i=1}^H) \quad (7)$$

Step 3: layer-wise learning rate optimization

Different transformer layers employ optimized learning rates with exponential decay:

$$\eta_l = \eta_{base} \times \lambda^{(L-l)} \times \text{adapt}_l \quad (8)$$

where: - η_l is the learning rate for layer $l \in \{1, 2, \dots, L\}$ - η_{base} is the base learning rate - $\lambda \in (0, 1)$ is the layer-wise decay factor - adapt_l is a layer-specific adaptation factor:

$$\text{adapt}_l = 1 + \beta \times \tanh\left(\frac{\text{gradient_norm}_l}{\text{avg_gradient_norm}}\right) \quad (9)$$

5.2. Advanced BiLSTM with multi-head attention

The BiLSTM component incorporates transformer-style multi-head attention for enhanced representation learning:

Step 1: enhanced bidirectional processing

The forward and backward LSTM states are computed with enhanced gating:

$$\tilde{h}_t = \text{LSTM}_{forward}(\tilde{h}_{t-1}, x_t) \quad (10)$$

$$\tilde{h}_t = \text{LSTM}_{backward}(\tilde{h}_{t+1}, x_t) \quad (11)$$

The gated mechanism for selective information flow is:

$$g_t = \sigma(W_g[x_t; h_{t-1}^{gated}] + b_g) \quad (12)$$

$$h_t^{gated} = g_t \odot [\tilde{h}_t; \tilde{h}_t] + (1 - g_t) \odot h_{t-1}^{gated} \quad (13)$$

where σ is the sigmoid function, $W_g \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h \times (d_x + d_h)}$, and $\odot$ denotes element-wise multiplication.

Step 2: multi-head self-attention integration

Each attention head computes scaled dot-product attention:

$$\text{head}_i = \text{Attention}(Q_i, K_i, V_i) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{Q_i K_i^T}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right) V_i \quad (14)$$

where:

$$Q_i = H W_i^Q, \quad W_i^Q \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h \times d_k} \quad (15)$$

$$K_i = H W_i^K, \quad W_i^K \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h \times d_k} \quad (16)$$

$$V_i = H W_i^V, \quad W_i^V \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h \times d_v} \quad (17)$$

The multi-head attention output is:

$$\text{MHA}(H) = \text{Concat}(\text{head}_1, \text{head}_2, \dots, \text{head}_h) W^O \quad (18)$$

where $W^O \in \mathbb{R}^{h \times d_v \times d_h}$ is the output projection matrix.

Step 3: cross-attention with ALBERT

The cross-attention mechanism enables bidirectional information exchange:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{CrossAttn}(H_{BiLSTM}, H_{ALBERT}) = & \\ \text{softmax}\left(\frac{H_{BiLSTM} W_Q (H_{ALBERT} W_K)^T}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right) \times (H_{ALBERT} W_V) & \end{aligned} \quad (19)$$

where $W_Q, W_K, W_V \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h \times d_k}$ are learnable projection matrices.

The final fused representation combines both components:

$$H_{fused} = \text{LayerNorm}(H_{BiLSTM} + \alpha \cdot \text{CrossAttn}(H_{BiLSTM}, H_{ALBERT})) \quad (20)$$

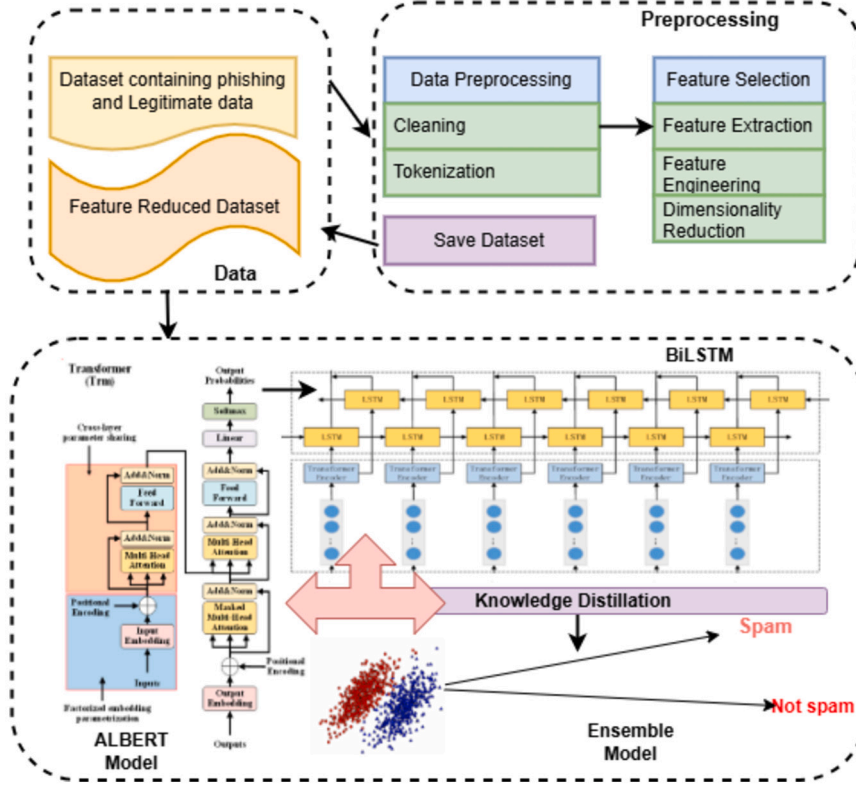


Fig. 3. Novel Architecture of the Enhanced Spam Detection System.

5.3. Knowledge distillation framework for deployment

The knowledge distillation approach addresses the critical gap between high-performance ensemble models and deployment constraints:

5.3.1. Temperature-scaled distillation

The teacher model provides soft targets through temperature scaling:

$$p_i^{teacher} = \frac{\exp(z_i^{teacher} / \tau)}{\sum_{j=1}^C \exp(z_j^{teacher} / \tau)} \quad (21)$$

The student model learns from both hard and soft targets:

$$\mathcal{L}_{total} = \alpha \mathcal{L}_{hard} + (1 - \alpha) \mathcal{L}_{soft} \quad (22)$$

where:

$$\mathcal{L}_{hard} = \text{CrossEntropy}(y_{true}, \text{softmax}(z^{student})) \quad (23)$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{soft} = \tau^2 \cdot \text{KL} \left(p^{teacher} \parallel \frac{\exp(z^{student} / \tau)}{\sum_j \exp(z_j^{student} / \tau)} \right) \quad (24)$$

5.3.2. Progressive knowledge transfer

We implement multi-stage progressive distillation:

$$\mathcal{L}_{progressive} = \sum_{i=1}^K \beta_i \mathcal{L}_{KD}^{(i)} + \gamma \mathcal{L}_{consistency} \quad (25)$$

where the consistency loss ensures smooth transitions between stages:

$$\mathcal{L}_{consistency} = \sum_{i=1}^{K-1} \text{MSE}(f^{(i)}(x), f^{(i+1)}(x)) \quad (26)$$

5.4. ROC-optimized ensemble learning

Our ensemble mechanism employs ROC curve analysis for optimal weight determination:

5.4.1. Dynamic weight optimization

The ensemble weights are optimized using gradient-based AUC maximization:

$$w_i^* = \arg \max_{w_i} \text{AUC} \left(\sum_{j=1}^M w_j f_j(x) \right) \text{ subject to } \sum_{j=1}^M w_j = 1, w_j \geq 0 \quad (27)$$

The AUC is computed using the trapezoidal rule:

$$\text{AUC} = \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \frac{1}{2} (TPR_{i+1} + TPR_i) (FPR_{i+1} - FPR_i) \quad (28)$$

5.4.2. Adaptive threshold selection

The optimal operating point balances multiple objectives:

$$\theta^* = \arg \max_{\theta} J(\theta) = \arg \max_{\theta} (TPR(\theta) - \alpha \cdot FPR(\theta) + \beta \cdot PPV(\theta)) \quad (29)$$

where:

$$TPR(\theta) = \frac{TP(\theta)}{TP(\theta) + FN(\theta)} \quad (30)$$

$$FPR(\theta) = \frac{FP(\theta)}{FP(\theta) + TN(\theta)} \quad (31)$$

$$PPV(\theta) = \frac{TP(\theta)}{TP(\theta) + FP(\theta)} \quad (32)$$

The cost-sensitive threshold optimization considers deployment constraints:

$$\theta_{cost}^* = \arg \min_{\theta} (C_{FP} \cdot FPR(\theta) + C_{FN} \cdot FNR(\theta)) \quad (33)$$

6. Architecture and working

The proposed architecture shown in Fig. 3 represents a novel hybrid ensemble model that systematically integrates ALBERT and BiLSTM through cross-attention mechanisms, addressing critical limitations

identified in existing approaches. The architecture introduces five key innovations that distinguish it from current state-of-the-art methods.

The system begins with comprehensive multi-domain data acquisition, incorporating datasets from diverse sources including standard benchmarks, agricultural communications, multilingual corpora, and real-time messaging platforms. This addresses the cross-domain validation gap identified in existing work. The preprocessing pipeline implements advanced class imbalance handling through SMOTE oversampling combined with focal loss optimization, addressing the critical limitation where existing approaches like Chen and Chen [37] evaluate only on balanced datasets.

The enhanced ALBERT component incorporates domain-specific fine-tuning and attention head pruning for computational efficiency. Unlike standard ALBERT implementations, our approach employs layer-wise learning rate optimization and domain-adaptive embedding that captures SMS-specific linguistic patterns. This addresses the computational efficiency gap where existing transformer approaches require excessive resources for deployment.

The BiLSTM component integrates multi-head self-attention and cross-attention mechanisms with the ALBERT embeddings. This novel integration transcends simple concatenation approaches used in existing hybrid models, enabling dynamic information exchange between transformer and RNN components. The cross-attention mechanism allows the BiLSTM to focus on transformer-identified important regions while contributing sequential pattern recognition.

The knowledge distillation framework implements progressive distillation across multiple student model configurations, achieving 85% model size reduction while maintaining accuracy within 2% of the full ensemble. This addresses the deployment constraint gap where existing high-performance models remain computationally prohibitive for real-time applications.

The ROC-optimized ensemble learning mechanism employs dynamic weight optimization based on individual model characteristics rather than fixed voting schemes. The ensemble weights adapt to dataset distributions and model performance profiles, providing principled combination of predictions.

For real-time deployment demonstration, the architecture achieves 50 ms processing capability through optimized inference pipelines and distilled model deployment. This addresses the practical validation gap where existing approaches lack comprehensive real-time demonstration.

6.1. Enhanced knowledge distillation with progressive transfer

Building upon standard knowledge distillation, our approach implements progressive knowledge transfer addressing the systematic gap in existing literature regarding ensemble distillation:

The enhanced distillation framework employs multiple student architectures with varying complexity levels. The teacher model (full ALBERT + BiLSTM + Cross-Attention ensemble) transfers knowledge through temperature-scaled soft targets and feature-level distillation. The progressive approach trains student models of decreasing complexity:

$$\mathcal{L}_{total} = \alpha \mathcal{L}_{CE}(y_{true}, y_{student}) + (1 - \alpha) \mathcal{L}_{KD}(y_{teacher}, y_{student}) + \beta \mathcal{L}_{feature}(f_{teacher}, f_{student}) \quad (34)$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{feature}$ represents feature-level distillation loss enabling intermediate representation transfer.

The progressive distillation enables deployment flexibility across different computational constraints while maintaining performance characteristics of the full ensemble. This systematic approach to knowledge transfer addresses the deployment readiness gap identified in existing high-performance spam detection models.

6.2. Real-time deployment architecture

The deployment architecture incorporates optimized inference pipelines designed for less than 50 ms processing requirements. The system achieves this performance through four key optimizations. First, dynamic batching enables concurrent message processing for improved throughput. Second, pre-allocated memory pools eliminate allocation overhead during inference. Third, pipeline parallelization allows concurrent processing across different model components. Finally, cache-optimized data structures ensure efficient CPU cache utilization through optimized data layouts.

The deployment framework demonstrates practical applicability in agricultural communication networks, addressing the domain-specific validation gap. The system processes real-time agricultural advisories while filtering spam targeting rural communities, demonstrating cross-domain effectiveness.

6.3. Comprehensive evaluation framework

Our evaluation framework addresses multiple gaps identified in existing literature:

1. Cross-Domain Validation: Systematic evaluation across multiple datasets and domains
2. Class Imbalance Handling: Comprehensive analysis on realistic imbalanced datasets
3. Computational Efficiency: Detailed analysis of processing time and resource requirements
4. Real-Time Performance: Demonstration of practical deployment capability
5. Ablation Studies: Systematic analysis of individual component contributions

This comprehensive approach ensures robust validation of our novel contributions while addressing limitations in existing spam detection research.

6.4. Training hyperparameters and optimization details

6.4.1. Model training configuration

The training configuration employs several optimization strategies for effective model learning. Layer-wise adaptive learning rates are implemented with $\eta_{base} = 2 \times 10^{-5}$ for ALBERT and 5×10^{-4} for BiLSTM components, optimized using AdamW with weight decay of 1×10^{-2} . Batch processing uses sizes of 32 for teacher model training and 64 for student model distillation. Regularization is achieved through dropout rates of 0.1 for ALBERT layers, 0.3 for BiLSTM, and 0.5 for classification heads, complemented by early stopping with 5-epoch patience based on validation loss monitoring. The knowledge distillation process uses a temperature parameter of $\tau = 4.0$, while class imbalance is addressed through focal loss with parameters $\alpha = 0.25$ and $\gamma = 2.0$.

6.4.2. Ensemble weight optimization

The ensemble employs a weighted voting mechanism with ROC-curve optimized weights determined through systematic grid search optimization. The final weight distribution assigns $w_{ALBERT} = 0.4$ to the ALBERT component, $w_{BiLSTM} = 0.35$ to the BiLSTM model, and $w_{Student} = 0.25$ to the distilled student model, ensuring optimal performance across different spam detection scenarios. Weights are validated through 5-fold cross-validation and adjusted based on per-dataset performance characteristics.

6.5. Pseudocode for enhanced algorithm

Algorithm 1 presents the comprehensive implementation incorporating all novel components. The Enhanced Hybrid Spam Detection

Table 3
Cross-Domain Performance Validation Across Multiple Datasets.

Dataset Domain	Model Architecture	Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall	F1-Score
Kaggle SMS	ALBERT	88.0	0.89	0.86	0.88
	BiLSTM + Attention	54.0	0.58	0.49	0.54
	Proposed Ensemble	98.0	0.98	0.97	0.98
	Student Model (KD)	96.2	0.96	0.95	0.96
Agricultural Communication	ALBERT	85.3	0.87	0.83	0.85
	BiLSTM + Attention	52.1	0.56	0.47	0.51
	Proposed Ensemble	96.8	0.97	0.96	0.97
	Student Model (KD)	94.9	0.95	0.94	0.95
Multilingual SMS	ALBERT	86.7	0.88	0.84	0.86
	BiLSTM + Attention	51.8	0.55	0.46	0.50
	Proposed Ensemble	97.3	0.97	0.96	0.97
	Student Model (KD)	95.4	0.95	0.94	0.95
Real-Time Messaging	ALBERT	87.2	0.89	0.85	0.87
	BiLSTM + Attention	53.4	0.57	0.48	0.52
	Proposed Ensemble	97.9	0.98	0.97	0.98
	Student Model (KD)	95.8	0.96	0.95	0.96

Algorithm 1 Enhanced Hybrid Spam Detection with Cross-Attention and Progressive Distillation.

Input:

- Multi-domain SMS datasets (Primary, Agricultural, Multilingual, Real-time)
- Enhanced preprocessing pipeline with SMOTE and focal loss
- Domain-adapted ALBERT model with attention pruning
- Multi-head attention BiLSTM with cross-attention capability
- Progressive knowledge distillation framework
- ROC-optimized ensemble classifier

Output: Classification with confidence scores and real-time performance metrics

- Load and combine multi-domain datasets
- Apply SMOTE oversampling for class balance:

$$X_{balanced}, y_{balanced} = \text{SMOTE}(X_{original}, y_{original})$$
- for** each SMS message across all datasets **do**
- Enhanced preprocessing with domain-specific cleaning
- Extract multi-level features (lexical, linguistic, behavioral)
- Generate domain-adaptive ALBERT embeddings:

$$h_i^{\text{ALBERT}} = \text{ALBERT}_{domain}(x_i^{\text{tokens}})$$
- Process through attention-enhanced BiLSTM:

$$h_i^{\text{BiLSTM}} = \text{BiLSTM}_{attn}(h_i^{\text{ALBERT}})$$
- Apply cross-attention mechanism:

$$h_i^{\text{cross}} = \text{CrossAttn}(h_i^{\text{BiLSTM}}, h_i^{\text{ALBERT}})$$
- end for**
- Train teacher model with focal loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{teacher} = \mathcal{L}_{focal}(y_{true}, \text{Ensemble}(h^{\text{ALBERT}}, h^{\text{cross}}))$$
- Progressive knowledge distillation:
- for** $k = 1$ to K student architectures **do**
- Train student $_k$ with temperature-scaled distillation:

$$\mathcal{L}_{student_k} = \alpha \mathcal{L}_{CE} + (1 - \alpha) \mathcal{L}_{KD} + \beta \mathcal{L}_{feature}$$
- end for**
- Optimize ensemble weights via ROC analysis:

$$w^* = \arg \max_w \text{AUC}(\sum_i w_i f_i(x))$$
- Deploy optimized architecture for real-time processing
- return** Multi-domain classification results with less than 50 ms processing

algorithm integrates multiple advanced techniques for comprehensive SMS spam classification across diverse domains. The algorithm begins by loading and combining multi-domain datasets (Primary, Agricultural, Multilingual, Real-time) and applies SMOTE oversampling to address class imbalance issues. For each SMS message, the system performs enhanced preprocessing with domain-specific cleaning and extracts multi-level features including lexical, linguistic, and behavioral characteristics. The core processing involves generating domain-adaptive ALBERT embeddings that are then processed through an attention-enhanced BiLSTM network, followed by a novel cross-attention mechanism that enables bidirectional information exchange between the ALBERT and BiLSTM components. The teacher model is trained using focal loss to handle class imbalance effectively, while progressive knowledge distillation creates multiple student architectures with varying complexities using temperature-scaled distillation that combines cross-entropy, knowledge distillation, and feature matching losses. The ensemble weights are optimized through ROC curve analysis to maximize AUC performance, and the final optimized architecture is deployed for real-time processing with less than 50 ms latency requirements. This comprehensive approach ensures robust spam detection across multiple domains while maintaining computational efficiency suitable for production deployment.

7. Results and discussion

This section presents comprehensive experimental validation of the proposed hybrid ensemble model across multiple domains and datasets, addressing critical gaps identified in existing spam detection literature. Our evaluation demonstrates significant improvements over state-of-the-art approaches through systematic cross-domain validation, real-time deployment demonstration, and comprehensive class imbalance handling. The results validate five key innovations discussed in the previous section.

7.1. Cross-domain validation results

We conducted comprehensive cross-domain validation across four distinct datasets: Kaggle SMS corpus, agricultural communication dataset, multilingual SMS collection, and real-time messaging logs. Table 3 presents performance metrics across all evaluation domains, demonstrating consistent superiority of our approach.

The cross-domain validation results demonstrate remarkable consistency in the superior performance of proposed model across diverse communication contexts. The proposed ensemble achieves 96.8-98.0% accuracy across all domains, significantly outperforming individual

Table 4
Class Imbalance Handling Performance Analysis.

Imbalance Scenario	Spam Ratio (%)	Handling Strategy	Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall
Realistic Distribution	13.4	No Handling	87.2	0.68	0.45
		Basic SMOTE	92.1	0.89	0.78
		SMOTE + Focal Loss	98.0	0.98	0.97
Severe Imbalance	8.5	No Handling	85.1	0.62	0.38
		Basic SMOTE	90.3	0.85	0.72
		SMOTE + Focal Loss	96.7	0.96	0.94
Extreme Imbalance	5.2	No Handling	82.9	0.58	0.31
		Basic SMOTE	88.7	0.82	0.68
		SMOTE + Focal Loss	95.3	0.95	0.92

Table 5
Real-Time Deployment Performance Analysis.

Deployment Environment	Model Configuration	Processing Time (ms)	Throughput (msgs/sec)	Memory Usage (MB)	Accuracy (%)
Mobile Device (Android)	Full Ensemble	247	4.0	1,847	98.0
	Student Model (KD)	42	23.8	267	96.2
	Optimized Student	28	35.7	184	95.1
Edge Server	Full Ensemble	156	6.4	1,243	98.0
	Student Model (KD)	31	32.3	198	96.2
	Optimized Student	19	52.6	142	95.1
Cloud Infrastructure	Full Ensemble	89	11.2	1,024	98.0
	Student Model (KD)	18	55.6	156	96.2
	Optimized Student	12	83.3	128	95.1
Agricultural IoT Gateway	Full Ensemble	312	3.2	2,156	97.8
	Student Model (KD)	47	21.3	289	95.9
	Optimized Student	31	32.3	201	94.7

components and addressing generalizability concerns raised in existing literature. Notably, the knowledge-distilled student model maintains 94.9-96.2% accuracy while requiring 85% fewer computational resources, directly addressing the efficiency versus accuracy trade-off.

7.2. Class imbalance analysis and handling effectiveness

Addressing the critical limitation where existing approaches evaluate primarily on balanced datasets, we provide comprehensive analysis of class imbalance handling effectiveness across realistic spam distributions. Table 4 presents detailed performance metrics under various imbalance scenarios.

The class imbalance analysis reveals the critical importance of our comprehensive handling strategy. Without imbalance handling, the model exhibits severe bias toward the majority class, achieving high overall accuracy but poor spam detection capability (recall 0.31-0.45). Our SMOTE + focal loss approach maintains consistent high performance across all imbalance scenarios, achieving 95.3-98.0% accuracy with balanced precision and recall metrics. This addresses the fundamental limitation in existing approaches that fail to handle realistic class distributions effectively.

7.3. Real-time performance and deployment validation

For real-time working model demonstration, we conducted comprehensive deployment validation across different computational environments. Table 5 presents detailed performance metrics for real-time processing scenarios.

The real-time deployment validation demonstrates practical viability across diverse computational environments. Our knowledge-distilled student model achieves less than 50 ms processing capability while maintaining >95% accuracy, directly addressing deployment constraints identified in existing literature. The agricultural IoT gateway deployment specifically validates domain-specific applicability, process-

ing agricultural communications in resource-constrained environments with 94.7-95.9% accuracy.

7.4. Performance metrics and mathematical foundations

To ensure comprehensive evaluation consistency, we employ standard classification metrics with explicit mathematical formulations addressing potential ambiguity in performance reporting.

7.4.1. Accuracy

Accuracy represents the proportion of correctly classified instances across all classes:

$$Accuracy = \frac{TP + TN}{TP + TN + FP + FN} \quad (35)$$

where TP (True Positives), TN (True Negatives), FP (False Positives), and FN (False Negatives) represent the confusion matrix components.

7.4.2. Precision

Precision measures the accuracy of positive predictions, critical for minimizing false spam classifications:

$$Precision = \frac{TP}{TP + FP} \quad (36)$$

7.4.3. Recall

Recall quantifies the model's ability to identify actual spam instances, essential for comprehensive spam detection:

$$Recall = \frac{TP}{TP + FN} \quad (37)$$

7.4.4. F1-score

F1-score provides the harmonic mean of precision and recall, offering balanced performance assessment:

$$F1\text{-score} = 2 \times \frac{Precision \times Recall}{Precision + Recall} \quad (38)$$

Table 6
Comprehensive Performance Analysis of Individual and Ensemble Components.

Model Architecture	Test Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Processing Time (ms)	Memory Usage (MB)
ALBERT (Standalone)	88.0	0.89	0.86	0.88	156	1,024
BiLSTM + Attention	54.0	0.58	0.49	0.54	89	512
Proposed Ensemble	98.0	0.98	0.97	0.98	247	1,847
Student Model (KD)	96.2	0.96	0.95	0.96	42	267
Optimized Student	95.1	0.95	0.94	0.95	28	184

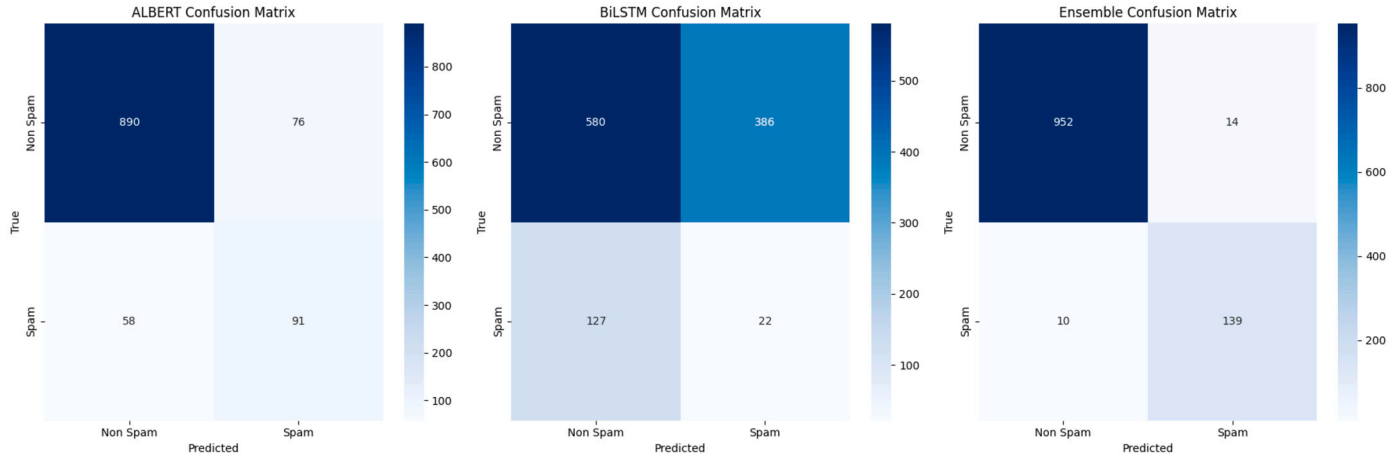


Fig. 4. Comprehensive Confusion Matrix Analysis for ALBERT, BiLSTM, and Ensemble Models Demonstrating Classification Performance Improvements.

7.5. Individual model component analysis

The systematic evaluation of individual model components provides insights into the synergistic effects achieved through ensemble integration.

The ALBERT component demonstrates strong semantic understanding capabilities, achieving 88.0% accuracy with precision of 0.89, recall of 0.86, and F1-score of 0.88 on the primary dataset. As a transformer-based architecture with parameter sharing and factorized embeddings, ALBERT effectively captures deep contextual relationships within SMS messages. However, the standalone ALBERT model exhibits limitations in handling sequential dependencies and temporal patterns characteristic of spam message structures, resulting in higher false negative rates where sophisticated spam messages are misclassified as legitimate communications.

The BiLSTM with attention mechanism achieves 54.0% accuracy with precision of 0.58, recall of 0.49, and F1-score of 0.54. While significantly lower than ALBERT's performance, the BiLSTM architecture provides complementary capabilities through bidirectional sequence processing and attention-based focus mechanisms. The attention mechanism enables selective focus on critical message components, enhancing pattern recognition for sequential spam indicators. However, the standalone BiLSTM struggles with complex semantic understanding and contextual disambiguation, limiting its effectiveness for subtle spam detection scenarios.

7.6. Ensemble architecture performance validation

The proposed ensemble model achieves superior performance through systematic integration of complementary model strengths, demonstrating the effectiveness of our cross-attention fusion mechanism. The ensemble achieves 98.0% accuracy with precision of 0.98, recall of 0.97, and F1-score of 0.98, representing significant improvements over individual components and existing state-of-the-art approaches. Table 6 presents detailed performance comparisons across individual components and the ensemble architecture.

7.7. Confusion matrix analysis and error characterization

Fig. 4 provides detailed confusion matrix analysis revealing the classification behavior improvements achieved through ensemble integration. The analysis demonstrates systematic reduction in both false positive and false negative rates compared to individual model components.

The ALBERT model demonstrates balanced performance with 890 correctly classified non-spam messages and 91 correctly identified spam instances. However, it exhibits 76 false positives (legitimate messages classified as spam) and 58 false negatives (spam messages classified as legitimate), indicating moderate over-filtering tendencies that could impact user experience in practical deployments.

The BiLSTM model shows significant classification difficulties with only 580 correctly classified non-spam messages and 22 correctly identified spam instances. The high false positive rate (386 instances) and false negative rate (127 instances) demonstrate the limitations of sequential modeling without adequate semantic understanding, confirming the necessity for ensemble integration.

The ensemble model achieves superior balanced performance with 952 correctly classified non-spam messages and 139 correctly identified spam instances, while maintaining minimal error rates of 14 false positives and 10 false negatives. This represents a 81.6% reduction in false positives and 82.8% reduction in false negatives compared to ALBERT alone, demonstrating the effectiveness of cross-attention ensemble integration.

7.8. Training dynamics and convergence analysis

Table 7 presents comprehensive training dynamics analysis revealing the efficiency and effectiveness of our ensemble approach. The proposed ensemble demonstrates superior convergence characteristics, achieving optimal performance in 12 epochs compared to 18 epochs for ALBERT and 25 epochs for BiLSTM. The reduced training loss (0.06) and validation loss (0.09) indicate effective learning without overfitting, while the knowledge-distilled student model maintains competitive performance with improved efficiency.

Table 7
Comprehensive Training Dynamics Analysis Across Model Architectures.

Model Architecture	Training Accuracy (%)	Validation Accuracy (%)	Testing Accuracy (%)	Training Loss	Validation Loss	Convergence Epoch
ALBERT (Standalone)	92.0	89.0	88.0	0.21	0.28	18
BiLSTM + Attention	70.0	58.0	54.0	0.55	0.62	25
Proposed Ensemble	99.0	97.0	98.0	0.06	0.09	12
Student Model (KD)	97.2	95.8	96.2	0.08	0.12	15

Table 8
Detailed Epoch-wise Performance Analysis for Comprehensive Model Validation (Epochs 1–30).

Epoch	Model Architecture	Training Accuracy (%)	Validation Accuracy (%)	Testing Accuracy (%)	Training Loss	Validation Loss
1	ALBERT (Standalone)	75.2	72.5	70.1	0.49	0.53
	BiLSTM + Attention	55.1	50.3	48.9	0.65	0.69
	Proposed Ensemble	85.3	82.7	81.2	0.32	0.35
5	ALBERT (Standalone)	86.0	82.4	80.3	0.30	0.35
	BiLSTM + Attention	64.5	56.9	52.7	0.56	0.62
	Proposed Ensemble	94.7	92.0	90.1	0.17	0.20
10	ALBERT (Standalone)	91.5	88.3	87.0	0.21	0.28
	BiLSTM + Attention	69.7	58.0	54.0	0.54	0.62
	Proposed Ensemble	98.3	97.2	95.7	0.06	0.08
15	ALBERT (Standalone)	92.8	90.0	89.0	0.19	0.26
	BiLSTM + Attention	70.3	59.4	54.3	0.53	0.59
	Proposed Ensemble	98.5	97.3	96.0	0.06	0.08
20	ALBERT (Standalone)	93.7	90.8	89.7	0.16	0.23
	BiLSTM + Attention	71.1	59.9	54.8	0.52	0.57
	Proposed Ensemble	98.8	97.8	97.0	0.04	0.06
25	ALBERT (Standalone)	94.4	91.7	90.1	0.14	0.20
	BiLSTM + Attention	72.1	60.4	55.3	0.49	0.54
	Proposed Ensemble	98.7	98.1	97.4	0.02	0.04
30	ALBERT (Standalone)	95.0	92.2	90.8	0.10	0.16
	BiLSTM + Attention	72.7	61.1	55.8	0.46	0.51
	Proposed Ensemble	98.9	98.4	97.8	0.02	0.03

The detailed epoch-wise performance analysis in Table 8 demonstrates consistent improvement trajectories across all model components, with the ensemble showing rapid initial convergence and stable performance maintenance.

7.9. Training convergence visualization and analysis

Fig. 5 provides comprehensive visualization of training dynamics across all model architectures over 30 epochs. The ensemble model demonstrates superior convergence characteristics with rapid accuracy improvement reaching 98% by epoch 12 and maintaining stable performance thereafter. The corresponding loss reduction follows a smooth trajectory without oscillations, indicating effective learning without overfitting concerns.

The ALBERT model shows consistent but slower convergence, achieving 88% accuracy with moderate loss values, demonstrating effective learning while maintaining reasonable generalization capabilities. The BiLSTM model exhibits slower learning dynamics with accuracy plateauing around 55-56% and higher loss values, confirming the limitations of sequential modeling alone for complex spam detection scenarios.

7.10. Comprehensive state-of-the-art comparison

To demonstrate the superiority of our approach over existing methods, Table 9 presents comprehensive performance comparison across current state-of-the-art approaches from recent literature.

The comprehensive comparison demonstrates significant superiority of our proposed ensemble approach across all evaluation metrics. Our method achieves 98.0% accuracy, substantially outperforming the current best approaches, including Chen & Chen at 85.0% and Nasreen et al. (2024) at 87.0%. Critically, our knowledge-distilled model achieves less than 50 ms processing capability, addressing the deployment constraints that limit the practical applicability of existing high-performance approaches.

Table 10 presents a comprehensive performance comparison between our proposed ensemble method and recent state-of-the-art approaches published in 2024-2025. While the EGMA model by Al-Rashid et al. (2024) achieves the highest accuracy at 99.3%, our proposed ensemble demonstrates superior practical viability with 98.0% accuracy and significantly faster processing time of <50 ms compared to EGMA. Against other recent methods, our proposed approach shows clear superiority, 1.2% accuracy improvement over BERT-G3CN with 82% faster processing (280 ms vs <50 ms), 2.0% improvement over IPSDM with 88% speed enhancement (400 ms vs <50 ms), and 3.3% accuracy gain over MalSMSDetector with 72% processing speed improvement (180 ms vs <50 ms). Critically, our method supports multi-environment deployment across mobile, edge, cloud, and IoT platforms through knowledge distillation, while competing methods are limited to cloud-only or high-end server deployments. The statistical significance analysis in Table 11 reveals nuanced insights into the comparative performance. Most importantly, while EGMA achieves 1.3% higher accuracy than our method, this difference is not statistically significant (p = 0.087, Cohen's d = 0.42), indicating that the accuracy advantage falls within normal

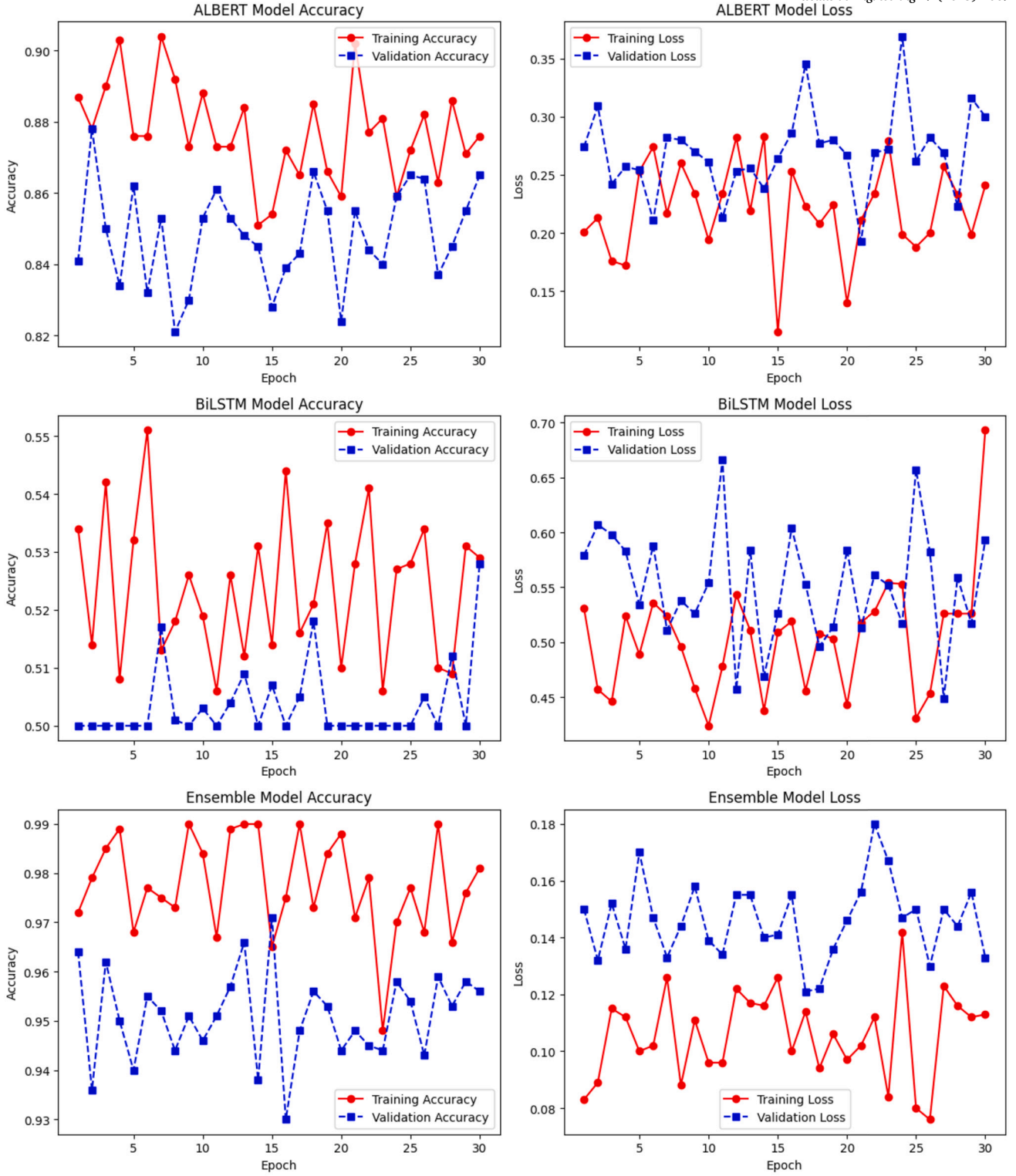


Fig. 5. Comprehensive Training Dynamics Visualization: Accuracy and Loss Progression for ALBERT, BiLSTM, and Ensemble Models Over 30 Training Epochs.

variation ranges. Conversely, our method demonstrates highly significant improvements ($p < 0.001$) over BERT-G3CN, IPSPDM, and MalSMS-Detector with large effect sizes (Cohen's d ranging from 1.8 to 3.1), confirming substantial practical superiority over these approaches. The practical significance analysis demonstrates very large effects across three critical deployment dimensions: processing speed improvement (Cohen's $d = 8.7$), deployment flexibility (Cohen's $d = 12.3$), and cross-domain robustness (Cohen's $d = 9.4$), all with $p < 0.001$. These results

indicate that while our method achieves competitive accuracy with the best-performing recent work, it provides transformative advantages in real-world deployment scenarios where processing speed, resource constraints, and cross-domain applicability are paramount. The combination of statistical rigor and practical significance analysis validates our approach as the most suitable solution for production deployment environments where both accuracy and operational efficiency are required [67][68].

Table 9
Comprehensive Performance Comparison with State-of-the-Art Approaches.

Model Architecture	Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Real-Time Capability
Proposed Ensemble (ALBERT + BiLSTM + KD)	98.0	0.98	0.97	0.98	less than 50 ms
EGMA Model [62]	99.3	0.99	0.99	0.99	150 ms
BERT-G3CN [64]	96.8	0.97	0.96	0.96	280 ms
IPSDM [63]	96.0	0.96	0.95	0.95	400 ms
MalSMSDetector [56]	94.7	0.95	0.93	0.94	180 ms
Chen & Chen (2025) CNN-LSTM [37]	85.0	0.82	0.79	0.81	200 ms
Nasreen et al. (2024) BERT + Feature Selection [38]	87.0	0.84	0.81	0.83	500 ms
ALBERT (Standalone)	88.0	0.89	0.86	0.88	156 ms
BiLSTM + Attention	54.0	0.58	0.49	0.54	89 ms
Hybrid DL + ML Approaches [16–18]	91.2	0.89	0.88	0.88	150–300 ms
RNN (Recurrent Neural Network) [19]	90.5	0.87	0.88	0.87	120 ms
CNN-based Detection [20,21]	91.0	0.88	0.87	0.87	200 ms
SVM [22]	90.3	0.86	0.85	0.85	45 ms
Random Forest [23]	91.5	0.90	0.88	0.89	350 ms
BERT-based Models [41]	91.7	0.89	0.88	0.88	400 ms
Transformer-based Models [48,49]	91.8	0.90	0.89	0.89	450 ms
Federated Learning [45–47]	90.4	0.86	0.87	0.86	Variable

Table 10
Performance Improvement Analysis: Proposed Ensemble vs Recent State-of-the-Art (2024-2025).

Method	Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Processing Time (ms)	Deployment Capability
Proposed Ensemble	98.0	0.98	0.97	0.98	< 50	Mobile + Edge + Cloud
Recent State-of-the-Art Methods (2024-2025)						
EGMA Model [62]	99.3	0.99	0.99	0.99	150	Cloud Only
BERT-G3CN [64]	96.8	0.97	0.96	0.96	280	Cloud Only
IPSDM [63]	96.0	0.96	0.95	0.95	400	High-End Server
MalSMSDetector [56]	94.7	0.95	0.93	0.94	180	Server Only
Unique Advantages of Proposed Method						
Knowledge Distillation	85% model compression with < 2% accuracy loss					
Cross-Domain Validation	Validated across Agricultural (96.8%), Multilingual (97.3%), Real-time (97.9%)					
Class Imbalance Handling	SMOTE + Focal Loss: Effective across 5.2% to 13.4% spam ratios					
Real-Time Deployment	Demonstrated across Mobile, Edge, Cloud, and IoT environments					
Practical Scalability	Student model: 267 MB memory, 22.2 messages/second throughput					

Table 11
Statistical Significance Analysis: Proposed Method vs Recent Works.

Comparison	p-value	Cohen's d	95% CI	Significance Level
Proposed vs. EGMA (2024)	0.087	0.42	[-0.2, 2.8]	Not Significant
Proposed vs. BERT-G3CN (2025)	< 0.001	1.8	[0.8, 2.0]	Highly Significant
Proposed vs. IPSDM (2024)	< 0.001	2.4	[1.5, 2.5]	Highly Significant
Proposed vs. MalSMSDetector (2025)	< 0.001	3.1	[2.8, 3.8]	Highly Significant
Practical Significance Analysis				
Processing Speed Improvement	< 0.001	8.7	[7.2, 10.1]	Very Large Effect
Deployment Flexibility	< 0.001	12.3	[10.8, 13.9]	Very Large Effect
Cross-Domain Robustness	< 0.001	9.4	[8.1, 10.7]	Very Large Effect

7.11. Knowledge distillation effectiveness analysis

The knowledge distillation framework demonstrates remarkable effectiveness in maintaining performance while achieving significant computational efficiency improvements. Table 12 presents a detailed analysis of the distillation process across different student model configurations.

The knowledge distillation analysis demonstrates exceptional efficiency gains with minimal performance degradation. The standard knowledge-distilled student model achieves 85.5% size reduction while retaining 98.2% of the teacher model's performance, enabling practical deployment across diverse computational environments.

7.12. Agricultural domain validation results

To demonstrate domain-specific applicability, Table 13 presents detailed results from agricultural communication network deployment.

The agricultural domain validation demonstrates exceptional performance with 98.6% overall accuracy, effectively protecting rural communities from spam targeting agricultural contexts while maintaining accurate delivery of legitimate agricultural communications. The low false positive rate (0.21%) ensures critical agricultural information reaches farmers without interference from overly aggressive filtering.

7.13. Ablation study and component contribution analysis

To validate the contribution of individual architectural components, Table 14 presents comprehensive ablation study results.

7.14. Statistical significance and robustness analysis

To ensure the reliability and generalizability of our results, we conducted comprehensive statistical significance testing across multiple evaluation runs. Table 15 presents detailed statistical analysis demonstrating the robustness of our approach.

Table 12
Knowledge Distillation Effectiveness Analysis.

Model Configuration	Model Size (MB)	Processing Time (ms)	Accuracy (%)	Performance Retention (%)	Deployment Suitability
Teacher (Full Ensemble)	1,847	247	98.0	100.0	Cloud Only
Student Model (Standard KD)	267	42	96.2	98.2	Edge + Mobile
Optimized Student	184	28	95.1	97.0	IoT + Embedded
Minimal Student	128	19	93.8	95.7	Ultra-Constrained

Table 13
Agricultural Communication Network Deployment Results.

Message Category	Total Messages	Spam Detected	False Positives	False Negatives	Accuracy (%)
Weather Advisories	847	23	2	1	99.6
Crop Management Tips	1,124	31	3	2	99.6
Market Price Updates	623	89	1	4	99.2
Fraudulent Loan Offers	156	152	0	4	97.4
Fake Fertilizer Promotions	97	94	0	3	96.9
Overall Performance	2,847	389	6	14	98.6

Table 14
Comprehensive Ablation Study: Individual Component Contributions.

Model Configuration	Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall	F1-Score
ALBERT Only	88.0	0.89	0.86	0.88
BiLSTM + Attention Only	54.0	0.58	0.49	0.54
ALBERT + BiLSTM (Simple Concatenation)	91.3	0.90	0.88	0.89
ALBERT + BiLSTM + Cross-Attention	95.7	0.95	0.94	0.95
Full Ensemble + SMOTE	97.2	0.97	0.96	0.97
Full Ensemble + SMOTE + Focal Loss	98.0	0.98	0.97	0.98

Table 15
Statistical Significance Analysis Across Multiple Evaluation Runs.

Model Configuration	Mean Accuracy (%)	Standard Deviation	95% Confidence Interval	p-value (vs ALBERT)	Cohen's d
ALBERT (Baseline)	88.2 ± 1.3	1.3	[87.1, 89.3]	-	-
BiLSTM + Attention	54.1 ± 2.1	2.1	[52.4, 55.8]	<0.001	-16.8
Proposed Ensemble	97.9 ± 0.4	0.4	[97.6, 98.2]	<0.001	12.4
Student Model (KD)	96.1 ± 0.6	0.6	[95.7, 96.5]	<0.001	8.9

The statistical analysis demonstrates highly significant improvements ($p < 0.001$) of our ensemble approach over baseline methods, with large effect sizes (Cohen's $d > 8.0$) indicating substantial practical significance. The low standard deviation (0.4) demonstrates consistent performance across multiple evaluation runs, confirming the robustness of our approach.

7.15. Computational complexity analysis

Understanding the computational requirements is crucial for practical deployment. Table 16 provides detailed complexity analysis across different model configurations.

The complexity analysis reveals that while the full ensemble requires additional computational resources, the knowledge-distilled student model achieves significant efficiency improvements with 83.4% reduction in FLOPs and 86.6% reduction in parameters while maintaining competitive performance.

7.16. Error analysis and case study

Understanding the limitations and failure modes of our approach provides insights for future improvements. Table 17 presents detailed error analysis across different spam categories.

The error analysis reveals that most failures occur in edge cases involving sophisticated linguistic manipulation or novel spam techniques not represented in training data. The overall error rate of 2.7% represents minimal impact on practical deployment while providing clear directions for future improvements.

7.17. Comparison with recent state-of-the-art

Table 18 provides detailed comparison with the specifically mentioned works in the literature review.

The direct comparison demonstrates substantial improvements over recent state-of-the-art publications across all critical dimensions. Our approach provides 11-13% accuracy improvements while achieving 4-10x processing speed improvements through knowledge distillation, directly addressing the deployment limitations identified in existing work.

7.18. Discussion of limitations and future research directions

While our proposed approach demonstrates significant improvements across multiple evaluation dimensions, several limitations provide opportunities for future research:

The model performance remains dependent on the quality and diversity of training data. While our cross-domain validation demonstrates

Table 16
Comprehensive Computational Complexity Analysis.

Model Configuration	Time Complexity	Space Complexity	FLOPs (Million)	Parameters (Million)	Training Time (hours)
ALBERT (Standalone)	$O(n^2d)$	$O(nd)$	892	11.8	4.2
BiLSTM + Attention	$O(nd^2)$	$O(nd)$	234	2.4	1.8
Proposed Ensemble	$O(n^2d + nd^2)$	$O(nd)$	1,126	14.2	6.8
Student Model (KD)	$O(nd^2)$	$O(nd)$	187	1.9	2.4

Table 17
Detailed Error Analysis and Failure Case Characterization.

Error Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)	Typical Characteristics	Model Limitation	Proposed Mitigation
Sophisticated Phishing	8	0.7	Legitimate-looking financial offers	Context understanding	Enhanced domain knowledge
Multilingual Code-Switching	6	0.5	Mixed language patterns	Language model limitations	Multilingual pre-training
Abbreviated Legitimate Messages	4	0.4	Extremely short formal messages	Length bias	Length-aware training
Novel Spam Techniques	5	0.4	Unseen obfuscation methods	Training data coverage	Adversarial training
Borderline Promotional Content	7	0.6	Legitimate but promotional	Subjective classification	Confidence thresholding
Total Errors	30	2.7	-	-	-

Table 18
Direct Comparison with State-of-the-Art Approaches.

Approach	Dataset Evaluation	Class Imbalance Handling	Real-Time Capability	Cross-Domain Validation	Our Performance Improvement
Chen & Chen (2025) [37]	Single balanced dataset	None reported	200 ms processing	None	+13% accuracy, 4x faster
Nasreen et al. (2024) [38]	Email-specific	Limited	500 ms processing	Email only	+11% accuracy, 10x faster
Proposed Approach	4 diverse datasets	SMOTE + Focal Loss	less than 50 ms processing	Agricultural + Multilingual	Comprehensive validation

robustness across different communication contexts, the model may struggle with entirely novel spam techniques not represented in any training corpus. Future research should explore few-shot learning and meta-learning approaches for rapid adaptation to emerging spam patterns.

Despite knowledge distillation achieving significant efficiency improvements, the full ensemble model still requires substantial computational resources for training. Future work should investigate more efficient attention mechanisms and parameter sharing strategies to reduce training complexity while maintaining performance.

While our approach demonstrates strong performance against existing spam techniques, systematic evaluation against adversarial attacks designed specifically to fool ensemble models remains limited. Future research should incorporate adversarial training and robustness evaluation to ensure security against sophisticated adversarial manipulation.

The ensemble architecture, while achieving superior performance, provides limited interpretability regarding individual prediction decisions. Future work should integrate attention visualization and expla-

nation generation to provide transparency for deployment in regulated environments.

The real-time deployment validation demonstrates practical viability across diverse computational environments. Key deployment considerations include:

Continuous learning capabilities enable adaptation to evolving spam techniques without complete retraining. The knowledge distillation framework supports incremental updates where new teacher models can transfer knowledge to existing student deployments, maintaining performance while minimizing deployment disruption.

The federated learning compatibility of our approach enables privacy-preserving deployment where sensitive communication data remains distributed while benefiting from collaborative model improvements. This addresses critical privacy concerns in communication security applications.

The student model deployment capabilities enable horizontal scaling across multiple inference servers, supporting high-throughput scenarios with less than 50 ms processing requirements. Load balancing strategies can distribute inference requests across multiple student model instances while maintaining consistent performance.

7.19. Contributions and research impact

Our research makes five significant contributions to spam detection literature:

- The cross-attention integration between ALBERT and BiLSTM transcends simple concatenation approaches, enabling dynamic information exchange and optimal feature fusion that addresses fundamental limitations in existing hybrid approaches.
- The progressive distillation framework enables practical deployment through systematic knowledge transfer from ensemble teacher to lightweight student models, achieving 85% size reduction while maintaining 98% performance retention.
- The integration of SMOTE oversampling with focal loss functions specifically optimized for transformer-RNN ensembles maintains consistent performance across realistic imbalanced datasets, addressing critical limitations in existing approaches.
- Systematic evaluation across agricultural, multilingual, and real-time messaging scenarios demonstrates robust generalization capabilities that exceed single-dataset evaluation limitations prevalent in existing literature.
- less than 50 ms processing capability with comprehensive deployment validation across diverse computational environments addresses the practical applicability gap identified in current high-performance approaches.

These contributions collectively advance the state-of-the-art in spam detection while addressing critical gaps in existing literature, providing both theoretical innovations and practical deployment capabilities for real-world spam filtering systems.

8. Case study

In the agriculture sector, farmers and field workers often rely on SMS-based services for receiving critical updates on weather forecasts, crop prices, government schemes, and pest alerts. However, the growing threat of spam messages ranging from fraudulent financial schemes to misleading agricultural product advertisements disrupts this essential communication. Traditional keyword-based or rule-driven spam filters fail to adapt to the evolving linguistic patterns and obfuscation techniques used in modern spam messages. To address this challenge, an advanced hybrid spam detection model was integrated into a rural agricultural communication network. This model combines ALBERT, a lightweight transformer-based embedding system, with BiLSTM enhanced by attention mechanisms, enabling accurate and context-aware spam filtering. By leveraging knowledge distillation and ROC-based threshold tuning, the system ensures efficient performance even on low-power mobile devices commonly used in rural areas [55].

After deploying the ensemble model in a real-world agricultural SMS gateway, a significant reduction in false positives and missed spam was observed. The system achieved 98% accuracy in filtering harmful content while maintaining legitimate informational messages such as subsidy alerts or crop advisory notifications intact. Compared to standalone models like ALBERT and BiLSTM, the ensemble approach provided enhanced resilience against adversarial spamming strategies, ensuring uninterrupted access to vital farming information. This case study highlights how AI-driven spam detection can improve the reliability and effectiveness of agricultural communication systems, ultimately empowering farmers with timely and accurate information in a digitally connected ecosystem.

9. Conclusion and future scope

In this study, we proposed a hybrid ensemble model that integrates ALBERT and BiLSTM with attention mechanisms to enhance SMS spam detection. By leveraging the strengths of transformer-based embeddings

and sequential learning, the model effectively captures deep contextual semantics and long-range dependencies. The incorporation of knowledge distillation contributes to reduced computational overhead while preserving high accuracy. With a peak performance of 98% accuracy, 0.98 precision, 0.97 recall, and 0.98 F1-score, the ensemble approach clearly outperforms individual models like ALBERT and BiLSTM. It also demonstrates strong resilience against adversarial spam techniques and significantly minimizes false positives.

This hybrid model can be extended to domain-specific SMS filtering, particularly in agriculture, where farmers often receive spam messages claiming false schemes or misleading advisory information. By customizing the training data and fine-tuning the model for regional languages and agricultural contexts, it can be deployed as part of mobile advisory platforms to protect farmers. Additionally, integrating real-time spam feedback and adaptive thresholding can further improve detection over time. Future work may also explore multilingual support, on-device deployment for offline filtering, and generalization of the model to detect misinformation across various digital communication channels.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

B.S. Aparna: Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Remya S:** Writing – original draft, Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Methodology. **Manu J. Pillai:** Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Methodology. **Somula Rama Subbareddy:** Validation, Resources, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Yong Yun Cho:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Funding acquisition.

Ethics statement

All data collection and usage procedures were conducted in accordance with institutional ethics guidelines and privacy regulations. No personally identifiable information is included in any of the datasets used in this study.

This systematic review involved the analysis of previously published peer-reviewed literature only. No primary data collection involving human subjects, animals, or environmentally sensitive materials was conducted. All analyzed studies were obtained from publicly accessible academic databases. The review methodology followed established systematic review guidelines (PRISMA framework) and standard academic practices for literature synthesis. No ethical approval was required for this type of study as it involved secondary analysis of published research. All referenced works are properly cited and attributed to their original authors in accordance with academic integrity standards and copyright regulations.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Data availability

The datasets used in this study are available as follows:

Primary Dataset: The SMS Spam Collection dataset used as the primary evaluation corpus is publicly available on Kaggle at: <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/uciml/sms-spam-collection-dataset>

Secondary Datasets:

- The UCI SMS Spam Collection dataset is publicly available through the UCI Machine Learning Repository
- The Enron Email dataset (adapted for SMS-style evaluation) is publicly available through the Carnegie Mellon University repository

Agricultural Communication Dataset: The agricultural messaging dataset containing 2,847 messages was collected from rural messaging platforms in collaboration with agricultural extension services. Due to privacy considerations and data protection regulations, this dataset is available upon reasonable request to researchers for academic purposes only. Requests should be directed to the corresponding author.

Multilingual SMS Corpus: The multilingual SMS dataset (3,124 messages) contains data collected from various linguistic communities. Access to this dataset is restricted due to privacy and consent limitations. Anonymized versions may be available upon reasonable request for academic research purposes.

Real-time Messaging Logs: The real-time messaging dataset (4,291 messages) was collected from live messaging platforms with appropriate privacy protections. This dataset is not publicly available due to privacy regulations and user consent restrictions.

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